



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi power network set for major upgrade Under Mission 2030



NATION: Pg 5

Vijay expands Cabinet with 23 more



FILM: Pg 14

'There's power in silence & composure'

PARLIAMENTARY PANEL GRILLS TOP NTA OFFICIALS

NEET paper leak not through our systems, NTA chief informs MPs

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Top officials of the National Testing Agency (NTA) appeared before a Parliamentary panel on Thursday to answer questions about the leaked NEET-UG 2026 question paper, with the agency's director general telling lawmakers that the breach did not occur through NTA's own systems and that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is looking into how it happened.

Members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports questioned NTA Director General Abhishek Singh directly: if the paper was not leaked through their system, then how did it leak, and why did the exam have to be cancelled and held again?

Singh did not offer a direct explanation, instead telling the committee that the CBI is handling the investigation. Opposition MPs demanded that the probe report be placed before the panel. BJP mem-



A police official passes by a poster during a protest staged by Youth Congress members over the alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG medical entrance exam, in Bengaluru, Karnataka, on Thursday

PTI

KEY POINTS

- » Opposition MPs demand CBI probe report be placed before panel
- » BJP MPs object, say CBI should work independently
- » 70% of Radhakrishnan Committee short-term reforms already implemented
- » NTA considering shift to computer-based testing for future exams
- » Agency faces 25 per cent staff shortage; vacancies being filled

Panel chief Digvijaya Singh says meeting "went off very well"

Take steps for comfort of people's lives, next Gen reforms, PM tells ministers

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday asked his ministers to align governance with the long-term goal of making India a developed nation by 2047, saying government action must focus on making daily life easier for citizens while preparing for future challenges, including the economic impact of the ongoing West Asia crisis. At the nearly four-and-a-half-hour Council of Ministers meeting in New Delhi, Modi called for faster decision-making, efficient delivery of welfare schemes and a forward-looking reform agenda as the NDA government approaches two years of its third term.

The meeting, held at Seva Teerth from 5 pm, was the first full Council of Ministers gathering this year and brought together cabinet ministers, ministers of state with independent charge, and ministers of state. According to sources, the session served as a midterm review of the government's performance and future priorities.

Modi told ministers that the vision of "Viksit Bharat" by 2047 should be treated as a concrete objective tied to governance reforms, not merely a political slogan. He said the focus must remain on "ease of living" and ensuring citizens face minimal disruption in their lives. Continued on P4



'NO CAUSE FOR PANIC'

India steps up Ebola vigilance, postpones Africa Summit



A Red Cross worker disinfects after transporting the bodies of people who died of Ebola from a health center in Rwampara, Congo

No Ebola case in India; meeting held with states to assess preparedness

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has implemented a series of health and diplomatic measures in response to the Ebola outbreak in Africa, including screening passengers at airports, conducting a national preparedness review, and postponing a major summit with African nations that was scheduled for later this month.

The Directorate General of Health Services issued a health advisory asking travellers arriving from or transiting through Ebola-affected countries to report to airport health authorities before clearing immigration if they have symptoms or a history of exposure to the virus. The advisory has been displayed at Delhi airport by the Airport Health Organisation and flags the Democratic Republic of Congo, Uganda and South Sudan as high-risk countries, following a classification by the World Health Organisation.

Passengers are being asked to watch for symptoms including fever, weakness, headache, muscle pain, vomiting, diarrhoea, sore throat and unexplained bleeding. Anyone who has had direct contact with the blood or body fluids of a

TAKEAWAYS

- » Airport screening intensified for travellers from DRC, Uganda and South Sudan
- » Symptomatic passengers must report before immigration clearance, per health ministry advisory
- » Ebola symptoms flagged: fever, weakness, vomiting, diarrhoea, sore throat, unexplained bleeding
- » Travellers developing symptoms within 21 days must seek care, disclose travel history

suspected or confirmed Ebola patient is required to report to the airport health officer or health desk immediately. The advisory also states that travellers who develop such symptoms within 21 days of arrival must seek medical care and inform authorities about their travel history.

On Wednesday, Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava chaired a high-level review meeting attended by health secretaries from all states and Union territories to assess the Continued on P4



Constitution not a privilege of few cosmopolitans, belongs to every citizen

CJI Surya Kant

In today's paper

...

CITY

'MCD SCHOOLS TO STAY OPEN' 3

NATION

NEET ROW: RAHUL SLAMS PM 5

EDIT

DEEPENING CRISIS 7

INTERNATIONAL

FLOTILLA ACTIVISTS BEING DEPORTED 8

BUSINESS

RUPEE RISES 50 PAISE TO 96.36 PER DOLLAR 10

SPORT

EAST BENGAL WIN ISL 12

Pulwama terror attack mastermind Burhan killed by unknown gunmen in PoK

LAHORE: Hamza Burhan, believed to be among the key planners of the 2019 Pulwama terror attack that killed more than 40 CRPF personnel, was shot dead in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir on Thursday, sources said.

Burhan, also known as Arjumand Gulzar Dar and Doctor, was a commander of the Al Badr terror group and had been designated a terrorist by India in April 2022 for involvement in multiple terror activities in Jammu and Kashmir.

Police said Burhan, who had allegedly been living undercover as a teacher after the Pulwama attack, was serving as principal of a private college in Gojra, Muzaffarabad, about 135 km from Islamabad. He was attacked at close range after stepping out of the college on Thursday morning. See P6

Ghaziabad Police book rape accused, supporters over procession after bail

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Ghaziabad police have filed a case against Hindu right leader Sushil Prajapati and about a dozen of his supporters for blocking traffic during a public procession held to mark his release from jail.

Prajapati walked out of Dasna jail on May 17 after spending roughly eight months in custody. He had been arrested on August 20, 2025, following a rape complaint lodged at Muradnagar Police Station earlier that month.

According to police, his supporters carried him on their shoulders and formed a vehicle convoy that disrupted traffic and put public safety at risk. The new FIR has been filed at Masuri Police Station after videos of the celebration drew criticism on social media. Continued on P4

Heatwave scorches India, Banda hottest at 47.6°C

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Large parts of India remained in the grip of intense heat on Thursday, with Uttar Pradesh's Banda once again recording the country's highest temperature at 47.6 degrees Celsius as weather officials warned that harsh conditions are likely to continue.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said heat wave to severe heat wave conditions prevailed in several parts of Haryana, Delhi, Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, adjoining Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Madhya Pradesh.

Delhi saw another punishing day, with temperatures hovering around 45 degrees Celsius. The Ridge weather station was the hottest in the capital at 45.3 degrees Celsius, followed by Ayanagar at 44.5 degrees, Palam and Lodhi Road at 44.3 degrees each, and

ROBBERY, 'FRIENDLY ENTRY' ANGLES PROBED

Woman & teen son stabbed to death in Govindpuri area

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 38-year-old woman and her teenage son were stabbed to death inside their house in southeast Delhi's Govindpuri area in the early hours of Thursday, with police suspecting robbery and a possible involvement of someone known to the family, police said. The victims were identified as Sharda Sahu, a homemaker, and her son, a 13-year-old class 7 student.

According to the police, a call about the killings was received at 1.11 am.

The bodies were discovered by the woman's husband, Vishnu Sahu, a fruit and vegetable vendor, who returned home around 12.30 am and found the front door latched from the outside, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Southeast) Hemant Tiwari said. After entering the house, he found his wife and son with multiple stab injuries, the officer said.

The police found some cash and jewellery missing from almirahs, indicating a robbery.

A crime team and forensic science laboratory (FSL) team were called to examine the spot and collect evidence, the officer said.



KEY POINTS

- » Bodies were discovered by the woman's husband, Vishnu Sahu, a fruit and vegetable vendor
- » He returned home around 12.30 am and found the front door latched from the outside: Police

The police have filed a case of murder and burglary and formed multiple teams to crack the case. Talking with the mediapersons, Joint CP, Southern Range, Vijay Kumar said, "We are investigating the case from every possible angle. So far, several leads and angles have emerged, and inquiries are being carried out on all of them." He said the teams are confident that they will solve the case soon.

"We are searching for CCTV footage. We have obtained some CCTV clips, and there are certain individuals visible in them whom we are trying to identify. However, this is still part of a very preliminary investigation. One important thing is that the entry into

the house appears to have been 'friendly'... meaning the victims may have known the person or persons involved," the officer said. Kumar said there were indications that either one or at most two individuals carried out the crime.

"As I mentioned earlier, we are working on multiple angles, and the nature of this friendly entry is a very important lead in the investigation," he added.

Family members alleged that cash worth Rs 8 to 10 lakh was missing and demanded an immediate arrest of the accused.

Victim Vishnu Sahu's brother said, "My sister-in-law and her son were stabbed multiple times on the back and stomach. When my brother

returned home, he found the house locked from the outside."

"The moment he entered the house, he found blood everywhere. I got a call from my brother at around 1 am. I immediately rushed to the spot and found both the victims lying in a pool of blood. Police must investigate the case from every angle and arrest the accused at the earliest," he said.

Another family member, Gudiya, alleged that around Rs 10 lakh was missing from the house and claimed that the money had recently been received through a local committee arrangement.

She also alleged that after the incident, the family members tried to seek help from a police vehicle passing near

their house, but it did not stop.

Police, however, said they are verifying all allegations made by the family and appropriate action would be taken if any lapse was found on the part of any personnel.

Investigators suspect the accused may have been familiar with the family or had prior access to the house, as there were no visible signs of forced entry, sources said.

Police teams are also examining CCTV footage from nearby lanes and questioning local residents, acquaintances, and people known to the family to establish the sequence of events leading to the murders.

Sources said the attackers were aware of her husband's timings and may have entered the house when the woman and her son were alone. Senior officers said technical surveillance, CCTV analysis, and interrogation of suspects are underway to identify those involved in the killings.

More than eight police teams have been formed to crack the murder case, with officers examining all possible angles, including robbery, known associates and CCTV footage of suspects, a senior officer said.

2020 RIOTS

High Court grants bail to Salim Malik in UAPA case

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday granted bail to Salim Malik in a case under anti-terror law UAPA concerning the "larger conspiracy" behind the February 2020 riots in the city's northeastern parts.

The relief was granted by a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain on Malik's appeal challenging a trial court order of January 29 that denied him bail in the case.

His counsel argued that he was entitled to bail in view of the Supreme Court granting the relief to identically placed co-accused Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmed. In its judgment, the court said Malik deserved to be released on bail as there was "no major distinction" between the role attributed to him and those who got relief from the top court.

It further said that Malik had been in custody for more than five years and ten months and since arguments on the charge were being heard, the trial was going to take some time.

"After having considered the role of the Appellant, this Court is of the view that the same is similar to the role which is attributed to Mohd. Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmad who had also participated in the meetings, protests and chakka jams. Under these circumstances, bearing in

Three convicted for rioting, unlawful assembly

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has convicted three men in a case linked to the 2020 north-east Delhi riots, holding that prosecutors proved they were part of an unlawful assembly involved in stone-pelting at police in Khajuri Khas. Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh said evidence showed the mob obstructed officials and injured several policemen during the February 24 violence.

The court ruled that membership of an unlawful assembly was sufficient to attract liability, even without specific overt acts by each accused. However, the accused were acquitted of charges related to arson, vandalism and use of deadly weapons, citing insufficient evidence.

Malik was represented by advocates Jawahar Raja and Archit Krishna.

The court asked Malik to execute a personal bond of Rs 2 lakh along with two sureties of the like amount, surrender his passport and not leave Delhi without permission.

It further directed Malik to appear before the Crime Branch SHO twice a week and fully cooperate with the trial.

The court also asked Malik not to influence witnesses, make any statement concerning the present case or its participants, circulate any handbills, posters, banners in any form or participate in any programme, rally or meeting till the conclusion of the trial.

"The Appellant shall maintain peace and good behaviour throughout and in the event of any offence committed during the pendency of the trial, the prosecution would be at liberty to seek revocation of the bail," clarified the court. Malik was booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for being one of the "masterminds" of the February 2020 riots that had left 53 people dead and more than 700 injured. The Supreme Court earlier granted bail to five accused in the Delhi riots conspiracy case, while denying relief to Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam.

RISHIKESH MYSTERY

Family fears foul play after Delhi vlogger goes missing

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 22-year-old Delhi-based vlogger has gone missing under mysterious circumstances in Uttarakhand's Rishikesh after allegedly sending a distress audio message to his family claiming he had been abducted and assaulted.

The missing youth, identified as Aman, a resident of Raghuvir Nagar in west Delhi, has remained untraceable since the night of May 8. Following his disappearance, Uttarakhand Police registered a missing person report at Kotwali Rishikesh police station



The missing youth, identified as Aman, a resident of Raghuvir Ngr in west Delhi, has remained untraceable since the night of May 8

in Dehradun district.

According to police records, Aman had travelled to Rishikesh with around 50 to 60 relatives and friends. He reportedly went missing near Haridwar Road while filming a vlog late at night.

The FIR stated that before

disappearing around 12.09 am on May 9, Aman allegedly sent an audio message to his family saying he was in a "very bad condition" and claimed unknown persons had deleted all videos from his mobile phone. His family suspects foul play.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 23-year-old woman was allegedly kidnapped, gang-raped and forced into marriage following a coerced conversion in Jamia Nagar here, police said on Thursday.

Four of the six accused, including a woman, have been arrested in southeast Delhi, while the main accused is currently lodged in Dasna jail in Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad in another case, an officer said.

According to police, the accused befriended the woman, who belongs to another religion, on social media using the fake identity.



The matter came to light on May 14 when the woman approached police and alleged that she was kidnapped and forced to marry the accused after conversion

The matter came to light on May 14 when the woman approached police and alleged that she was kidnapped and forced to marry the accused after conversion.

She told the police that she was sexually assaulted by the accused between 2021 and 2025.

Based on her complaint, police registered a case

under Sections 366 (kidnapping, abducting or inducing a woman to compel her marriage), 376 (rape), 506 (criminal intimidation), 342 (wrongful confinement) and 120B (criminal conspiracy) of the Indian Penal Code.

Police sources said the accused was also involved in illegal gun trading. A police officer said so far,

police have not found any guns during the raids conducted by the team. "We have also procured a transit remand of the main accused, and he will be brought to Delhi for investigation. Teams will also take the accused to the crime spot to understand the sequence of the events," the officer said.

Further investigation is underway.

Man caught for killing brother-in-law: Cops

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 30-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly murdering his brother-in-law near Burari Metro Station in north Delhi following a matrimonial dispute, police said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Jitender Kumar from Bihar's Sheikhpura district, allegedly killed Raja Kumar, a resident of Jharoda Majra, by repeatedly attacking him with a stone before dumping the body in a pit near a pipeline area close to the metro station.

Police said the murder was linked to long-standing domestic tensions involving the accused and his wife, who had been staying with the victim's family for the past month due to marital issues.

'Murder was linked to long-standing domestic tensions'

According to investigators, an argument broke out on May 10 when Jitender visited the house to meet his wife. During the altercation, Raja allegedly slapped him. Later, Raja accompanied Jitender to Burari Metro Station on a scooter but never returned home.

Police recovered the partially decomposed body on May 13 following a PCR call. During interrogation, Jitender allegedly confessed to the crime, claiming he acted out of anger and humiliation. The murder weapon, scooter and clothes used during the offence have been recovered.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 37-year-old habitual offender, who allegedly posed as a bike taxi rider to target unsuspecting late-night passengers before snatching their mobile phones and fleeing, was arrested, officials said on Thursday.

Police said the accused, Munender, a resident of Singhu village in outer north Delhi, used a stolen motorcycle to carry out the crimes and specifically targeted passengers by offering rides at cheaper fares during night hours.

"The case came to light after a man approached police on May 20 alleging that a bike taxi rider had snatched his mobile phone near Hans Bhawan on

TAKEAWAYS

» The case came to light after a man approached police on May 20 alleging that a bike taxi rider had snatched his mobile phone: Police

» The complainant had booked a ride to Okhla when the rider allegedly offered a cheaper fare

BSZ Marg in the ITO area," a senior police officer said.

According to the police, the complainant had booked a ride for Okhla when the rider offered him a lower fare and persuaded him to travel without using the application. Near



and convinced him to travel offline

» The accused allegedly asked the passenger to get off the motorcycle, citing a police check

BSZ Marg, the accused allegedly asked the passenger to get off the motorcycle on the pretext of a police check due to the absence of a helmet.

"As soon as the complainant started crossing the road, the rider snatched his mobile

phone and sped away," an officer said.

An FIR was registered at the IP Estate police station. A police team analysed CCTV footage and developed local intelligence inputs before tracing and arresting the accused from the Vikas Marg area.

During interrogation, Munender allegedly confessed to his involvement in multiple cases. Police recovered the complainant's phone, another stolen mobile phone linked to a separate case in north Delhi, and the motorcycle used in the offence, which was found stolen from the Narela area.

The police said the accused was previously involved in several theft and snatching cases across Delhi.

AIIMS team advances spinal surgery for kids

NEW DELHI: A team of doctors at All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) has developed an advanced spinal surgery approach that could significantly improve treatment outcomes for children suffering from severe scoliosis, a complex condition marked by abnormal curvature of the spine.

The research, led by senior orthopaedic spine surgeon Dr. Bhavuk Garg, focuses on improving surgical techniques for complicated spinal deformities that often affect children's posture, mobility, breathing capacity and overall physical development. According to specialists, severe scoliosis can progressively interfere with daily activities and reduce

quality of life if not treated at an early stage.

The newly developed surgical method is aimed at making corrective spine procedures safer and more effective. Doctors believe the technique may help reduce complications associated with surgery and anaesthesia while also improving long-term recovery and spinal balance in young patients.

Medical experts noted that the innovation could minimise the need for repeated surgeries and support better lung development and physical growth among children affected by complex spinal conditions. The study has been published in an Indian spine journal and is being seen as a significant advancement in the field.

TRUCKERS, TAXI OPERATORS PROTEST CESS HIKE AND RISING CNG PRICES

Transport strike disrupts travel, commuters face delays

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Commuters faced hardships while travelling in certain areas as several transport and taxi unions began a three-day strike in the Delhi-NCR on Thursday to protest against a city government cess and rising CNG prices.

The three-day strike till May 23 is primarily against the Delhi government's decision to hike the environment compensation cess on commercial vehicles.

Commuters faced difficulties at some of the busiest places in the national capital, including New Delhi Railway Station, Anand Vihar,

Mandi House metro and other locations.

Trucks remained parked in industrial areas like Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar as part of the protest.

"We tried booking a taxi for our home, but the wait time was taking longer than usual, and there were very few auto-rickshaws also available at the station. The cost of cab booking was also high," a commuter said.

The strike call was given by the AIMTC, the apex body of truckers, private buses, taxi and maxi cab operators, on Tuesday.

"We support efforts to reduce pollution, but despite



collecting nearly Rs 1,500 crore through the Environmental Compensation Cess over the last 10-12 years, the government has not properly used the funds for transport welfare, parking, roads, or pollution-control measures," Harish Sabharwal, National President, All India Motor Transport Congress (AIMTC), told PTI video.

ers' unions in Delhi have also extended support to the strike, demanding a hike in taxi and auto fares in view of the increasing fuel prices.

According to a transporters' union statement, the strike opposes the "unjust and unfair policies imposed by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), courts and the Delhi government on the transport sector".

Anuj Kumar Rathore, vice-president of the 'Chaalak Shakti Union', said that due to the continuously increasing prices of CNG, petrol and diesel, middle-class drivers are struggling to support their families.

"Therefore, in coordina-

tion with other organisations of Delhi, the 'Chaalak Shakti Union' has called for a 'chakka jam' and appealed not to operate vehicles on May 21, 22 and 23," he said.

An auto-rickshaw driver said, "The prices of petrol and diesel have increased, but the minimum charge in our autos remains the same; customers do not pay extra, the government has not changed the rules. It is becoming difficult to afford food amid inflation".

The 'Chaalak Shakti Union' on Monday wrote to Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on their demands.

DELHI SEES STEEPER MAY POWER DEMAND THAN EARLIER YEARS

Power demand scales season high

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi sizzled on Thursday, pushing peak power demand to this summer season's highest of 8231 MW, discom officials said.

According to Delhi's State Load Dispatch Centre (SLDC), the demand crossed the 8,000 mark for the first time in the intense summer heat this year on Wednesday.

The city recorded a maximum temperature of 43.6 degrees Celsius on Thursday.

Delhi's peak power demand in 2026 was higher than the corresponding days of 2025 on 16 out of 21 days and higher than 2024 on 14 out of 21 days, officials said.

BSES discoms — BRPL and BYPL — successfully met the peak power demand in their respective areas, with BRPL meeting a load of 3,762 MW and BYPL meeting 1,838 MW between May 1 and May 21,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The city recorded a maximum temperature of 43.6 degrees Celsius on Thursday
- » Delhi's peak power demand in 2026 was higher than the corresponding days of 2025 on 16 out of 21 days and higher than 2024 on 14 out of 21 days
- » Delhi is expected to witness another significant rise in electricity demand this summer

said the company spokesperson. The peak power demand has seen a sharp rise in May 2026 compared to previous years in Delhi, reflecting the impact of an intense and early summer.

Earlier, on April 27, 2026, Delhi's peak power demand crossed the 7,000 MW mark for the first time in April, touching 7,078 MW at 3:30 pm.

In comparison, the 7,000 MW level was reached only in May during 2024 and 2025.

Delhi is expected to witness another significant rise in electricity demand this summer.

According to SLDC projections, Delhi's peak power demand is expected to cross 9,000 MW this year, against the all-time high peak demand of 8,656 MW recorded in 2025.

A company spokesperson said Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) successfully met the season's peak demand of 2331 MW to date seamlessly across its network.

Discom officials said they made preparations to meet the rising demand for power through power purchase agreements, the use of technology and the use of green energy.

Logs hottest May night in 14 yrs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded its warmest night in the month of May in nearly 14 years as the minimum temperature settled at 31.9 degrees Celsius on Thursday, the weather office said.

The last time the minimum temperature was higher than this was on May 26, 2012, when the minimum temperature settled at 32.5 degrees Celsius.

Safdarjung and Lodi Road were among the stations that recorded warm night conditions, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

A warm night is declared when the maximum temperature remains 40 degrees Celsius or more and the minimum temperature departure is between 4.5 degrees Celsius and 6.4



degrees Celsius above normal, according to the IMD. Among the weather stations, Safdarjung recorded a minimum temperature of 31.9 degrees Celsius, 5.2 notches above the season's normal, followed by Ridge at 30.6 degrees Celsius, 4.4 notches above normal.

Palam stood at 30.5 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above normal, Lodi Road at 29.6 degrees

Celsius, 4.6 notches above normal, and Ayanagar at 27.4 degrees Celsius, 0.7 notch above normal. The city has been placed under an orange alert as the maximum temperature is expected to touch 46 degrees Celsius, with the IMD forecasting heatwave conditions during the day. The air quality was recorded in the 'moderate' category at 9 am on Thursday.

Delhi govt steps up vigil ahead of Eid-ul-Azha

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With Eid-ul-Azha set to be celebrated on May 28, the Delhi government on Thursday directed officials to intensify enforcement against illegal slaughter, unauthorised animal trade and cruelty towards animals across the national capital, according to a statement. During a review meeting, Delhi Development Minister Kapil Mishra said stringent action must be taken against illegal transportation of animals, illegal slaughter and cruelty towards animals. Mishra said, "To ensure animal welfare and public hygiene during Eid-ul-Azha, permission for sacrifice should be allowed only at authorised and designated locations."

He also directed the complete ban on the slaughter or sacrifice of cows, calves, camels and other prohibited animals must be strictly enforced.

The minister also instructed that no sacrifice should take place on roads, streets or other public places. Buying and selling animals in public spaces is illegal, and strict action should be taken on complaints, he said.

Mishra directed officials to ensure that animal blood does not flow into roads, drains or canals and that remains left after sacrifice are disposed of according to prescribed safety standards. Referring to the guidelines issued by the Animal Welfare Board of India, the minister said effective implementation of laws related to animal protection and welfare is necessary. Mishra said cruelty towards animals is punishable under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, and directed officials to register criminal cases in instances of illegal transportation of animals, operation of illegal slaughterhouses and other violations.

3 multi-level parking projs to come up in Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three underground multi-level parking facilities are set to be established in Delhi, with the proposal scheduled for discussion during the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's (MCD) House meeting on May 25.

According to the agenda circulated for the meeting, the projects are planned for New Friends Colony, Jangpura, and Kalkaji under the Central Zone.

The proposal seeks approval for a revised contractual amount of Rs 107.44 crore, an increase from the earlier amount of Rs 104.20 crore for work already completed. Additionally, the civic body will also consider granting revised administrative approval and expenditure sanction for the project, increasing the total project cost from Rs 104.20 crore to Rs 131.19 crore, the agenda stated.

Beyond the parking projects, the House agenda includes proposals regarding the extension of contracts for the collection and transportation of municipal solid waste and street sweeping in the South and West zones.

A proposal for constructing a community centre in C-Block, Seemapuri, under the Shahdara (North) Zone is also included in the agenda.

Officials said the elections for ward committees and the six vacant seats on the Standing Committee, originally scheduled for May 23, have been postponed and are now likely to take place on June 3.

The previously scheduled ward committee elections on May 19 have also been rescheduled to May 29. WITH PTI INPUTS

Delhi govt to revive rainwater harvesting at its 75 schools: CM

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As Delhi braces for the monsoon, the city government has launched a major rainwater conservation initiative aimed at transforming schools into hubs of sustainable water management. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday announced that rainwater harvesting systems in 75 CM Shri Schools across the Capital will be revived and made fully functional before the rainy season, with the project expected to conserve nearly 50 crore litres of water annually.

The initiative is part of the Delhi government's broader push to strengthen groundwater recharge and promote water conservation awareness among students and local communities. "The objective is not only to conserve rainwater but also to build long-term awareness about responsible water use among children and society," CM Rekha Gupta said.

According to officials, a comprehensive audit of rainwater harvesting systems in all 75 schools has already been completed. The inspection revealed that while many schools had existing structures, several had remained unused or poorly maintained for years. In many cases, pits were clogged with silt, plastic waste and debris, while rainwater was found flowing directly into drains instead of being conserved.

The Chief Minister said Delhi receives nearly 775 mm of annual rainfall and even a rooftop area of around 2,500 square feet can help conserve approximately two lakh litres of water every year. "This amount can meet the annual water needs of a family of five," she noted.

The government plans to



“The objective is not only to conserve rainwater but also to build long-term awareness about responsible water use among children and society — CM

implement the 'Ehsaas' rainwater harvesting model, approved by the Delhi Jal Board in 2021. The system is considered cost-effective, space-efficient and low-maintenance. Under the model, rainwater collected from rooftops will be filtered and channelled into storage systems and borewells to support groundwater recharge.

Officials said corrective measures will include desilting pits, replacing filter media, repairing drainage connections and improving maintenance access. The government will also create a dedicated maintenance budget for the systems.

"The Delhi Government is committed to turning water conservation into a people's movement," the Chief Minister said, adding that awareness workshops for students, teachers and parents will also be organised as part of the campaign.

MCD schools to stay open: Mayor Wahi

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Thursday dismissed allegations by the Opposition that Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) primary schools were being shut down to make way for Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, calling the claims "completely baseless" and politically motivated.

Addressing a press briefing, the Mayor said all 1,514 MCD primary schools that were operational when the BJP assumed power in Delhi and later regained control of the civic body continue to function without closure. According to him, nearly 6.5 lakh students are currently enrolled in these schools.

Wahi said the BJP-led civic administration is focusing on improving the quality of

municipal education and aims to transform all MCD schools into institutions comparable to English-medium private schools by 2032. He added that the corporation is also working towards establishing "Nigam Shri Vidyalayas" modelled on the Delhi government's specialised schools.

The Mayor stated that the civic administration, under the leadership of Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is committed to strengthening infrastructure and educational facilities in municipal schools to provide students with improved learning opportunities.

Rejecting allegations made by Leader of Opposition Anshu Narang, Wahi asserted that no MCD school has been shut and claimed that student enrolment in municipal schools has, in fact, increased.

MCD nears CSR-backed dog shelter plan in Dwarka

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has received a proposal from a private multinational conglomerate to set up a dog shelter in Dwarka Sector 29, with the civic body close to finalising the plan, senior officials said on Thursday.

The proposed shelter is likely to come up by the company which specialises in infrastructure development, airports, energy, transportation and urban infrastructure under its corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiative, while the MCD has also issued instructions to increase feeding points for stray dogs across the city substantially, officials added. "There are

close to 700 designated feeding points in the national capital. Instructions have been issued to substantially increase the number of feeding points in the city," a senior MCD official aware of the matter said. Officials said the civic body is also working on a euthanasia protocol in line with Supreme Court directions and the policy will be implemented after wider consultation.

"The proposed mechanism will include at least three members associated with the policy to ensure cases are handled as per prescribed norms and Supreme Court directives are followed," a senior MCD official said, adding euthanasia is a sensitive issue and will be taken up as a last resort. Under the

Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023, incurably ill and mortally wounded dogs, as diagnosed by a team appointed by the Local Animal Birth Control Monitoring Committee, may be euthanised humanely by a qualified veterinarian through intravenous administration of sodium pentobarbital or any other approved method.

Further, the MCD will identify land in coordination with the Delhi government's Animal Husbandry Department, and develop additional kennels and shelters to house aggressive stray dogs following the Supreme Court's recent directions on stray dog management, officials said on Thursday. A senior MCD official said that the

commissioner has directed officials to identify suitable land for the shelters in consultation with the Animal Husbandry Department. "We will identify land as per suitability so that shelters can be developed and aggressive dogs can be housed there," a senior MCD official said.

The decision was taken after MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar held a meeting with officials of the civic body's veterinary department following his visit to the Animal Birth Control (ABC) Centre at Bela Road.

According to officials, commissioner has also reviewed space earmarked for a pet crematorium at Bela road, which officials said is likely to be developed under the public-private

partnership (PPP) mode.

Officials further said the civic body is planning shelters in accordance with prescribed norms, under which around 20 square feet of space is required per dog. "If a shelter is planned for 100 dogs, a separate space will also be needed for isolation wards, clinical areas and food storage facilities. In such a case, nearly 2,800 square feet of space would be required," an official said. Officials said the MCD has made budgetary provisions this financial year for multiple initiatives related to stray dog management, including Rs 20 crore for microchipping, Rs 20 crore for sterilisation programmes and another Rs 20 crore for the development of dog shelters.

GOVT IS WORKING TOWARDS BUILDING A MODERN AND RESILIENT POWER INFRA UNDER THE VISION OF 'VIKSIT DELHI': MINISTER SOOD

Delhi power network set for major upgrade Under Mission 2030

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi is set for a major transformation of its electricity system under the "Mission 2030" plan, which aims to ensure 24x7x365 reliable, economical, safe and quality power supply to every citizen of the national capital by 2030. Speaking to *Millennium Post*, Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood said the government is working towards building a modern and resilient power infrastructure under the vision of "Viksit Delhi". The plan focuses on improving reliability, safety, and efficiency across the entire distribution network while preparing the system for future demand growth.

Reliability Targets for Power Supply

The government has set clear performance targets for improvement in supply reliability. Average power cuts per consumer per year are proposed to be reduced from less than 3 to less than 1, while total annual outage duration is expected to come down from around 120 minutes to 60 minutes. At the

same time, average restoration time at the 11 kV level is targeted to improve from about 45 minutes to less than 30 minutes. The distribution transformer failure rate is also planned to be reduced from 0.53 per cent to 0.25 per cent, indicating a significant push towards improving system stability and reducing disruptions for consumers.

Rising Demand and Existing Power Infrastructure

The capital's electricity demand is projected to rise sharply in the coming years. Peak demand is expected to grow from current levels towards around 11,164 MW under a business-as-usual scenario and up to 13,114 MW under an accelerated "Viksit Delhi" growth scenario. At present, Delhi's network includes 114 grid substations, 7,214 MVA of extra high voltage transformation capacity across 293 units, 7,437 MVA of distribution transformer capacity across 11,161 units, 9,331 circuit kilometres of 11 kV lines, and 15,234 circuit kilometres of low tension lines. Officials have noted that years of under-

investment have created stress in several parts of the network, affecting reliability and safety.

Mission 2030 Investment Outlay

Under Mission 2030, the total planned investment is more than Rs.17,000 crore, aimed at large-scale strengthening and modernization of Delhi's power infrastructure. For the financial year 2025–26 alone, Rs.1,426 crore has already been spent, reflecting accelerated implementation of network upgrade works across substations, feeders, and distribution systems.

Infrastructure Upgrade and Modernisation Plan

To address these challenges, the plan proposes large-scale infrastructure upgrades including capacity expansion, strengthening of the distribution backbone, and modernization of last-mile connectivity. It also includes conversion of overhead lines into underground cables in key corridors, shifting from HVDS to LVDS systems in selected areas, and deployment of battery storage and demand



Power Minister Ashish Sood

response systems. The network is also being upgraded to support electric vehicle charging infrastructure and rooftop solar expansion under schemes such as PM Surya Ghar, along with the rollout of smarter digital services including smart meters, faster connections, and improved billing transparency.

Digital Twin Technology for Smart Grid Management

A major technological upgrade under the plan is the introduction of a Digital Twin system, which will create a real-time virtual replica of the

physical electricity network. It will integrate data from GIS, SAP, IoT sensors, smart meters, FRTUs, and outage systems to enable real-time monitoring of grid health. This system will allow faster fault localisation, predictive maintenance, outage forecasting, load flow analysis, and better crew deployment, while also improving customer communication and system planning through scenario-based simulations.

Investment Plan for Hari Nagar Constituency

In Hari Nagar constituency,

planned investments include capital expenditure of 170.9 crore rupees during 2016–25, 26.6 crore rupees in 2025–26, and 222.3 crore rupees during 2027–29. The plan includes addition of 102 distribution transformers, 18 circuit kilometres of 11 kV lines, and 62.5 circuit kilometres of low tension lines, along with a business plan expenditure of 144.2 crore rupees and additional schemes worth 104.8 crore rupees. These additional works include undergrounding of 36.8 circuit kilometres of EHV lines and 6.2 circuit kilometres of HT lines at a cost of 49.4 crore rupees, installation of 6 LVDS transformers of 4.7 MVA capacity costing 13.9 crore rupees, installation of 180 motorised RMUs costing 32.2 crore rupees, and deployment of 214 distribution transformer monitoring units costing 28.8 crore rupees.

Transformer Failures and Procurement Issues

Officials also highlighted operational challenges in the system. Since 2020, 18 power transformers have been damaged, including 11 that failed

before completing their expected 25-year life cycle. In the absence of new procurement, 5 transformers were replaced using loan units from other utilities, 7 were shifted from other substations, and 1 was diverted from the project department. No new power transformer has been fully replaced in the last five years, despite repeated tenders for 500 MVA, 160 MVA, and 100 MVA transformers being floated and dropped multiple times between 2019 and 2025.

Project Delays and Execution Status

Implementation delays were also noted in infrastructure schemes under the 14th Five Year Plan. Out of 18 substation projects, only one has been commissioned so far, while land is not available for six, five have not yet been designed, and others are under revision or pending tendering. Similarly, out of 24 transmission line projects, only four have been completed, while several are delayed due to land constraints and repeated re-tendering. Officials also noted that repeated

delays have led to cost escalation and extended timelines in multiple cases.

Power Outage Performance and Workforce Issues

On system performance, there were 45 instances of outages lasting more than one hour, six instances exceeding two hours, and one major outage lasting 9.28 hours at Lodhi Road substation. Additionally, 31 employees from IPGCL have been working in diverted capacity since 2016, including senior HR officials since 2021, which officials said has impacted administrative functioning and coordination.

Long-Term Investment Plan for Transmission

Delhi Transco Limited's 15th Business Plan for 2027–32 proposes a total investment of 7,795 crore rupees, including 6,886 crore rupees for 2027–32 and 909 crore rupees for 2025–27. The plan focuses on strengthening transmission infrastructure and ensuring a robust 24x7 power supply system for the capital as part of the long-term "Viksit Delhi" roadmap.

TOP COURT STRESSES TRANSPARENCY

SC seeks subordinate legislation for environmental compensation charges

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday said that state pollution control boards cannot impose environmental compensation charges without the formulation of subordinate legislation.

A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe issued the direction after the Centre said that a new law is being formulated while taking into account several other aspects related to environmental protection.

The bench said the clarification is necessary as several high courts have passed orders staying the collection of environmental compensation charges only on the ground of the formulation of subordinate legislation.

Additional Solicitor General Archana Pathak Dave, appearing



for the environment ministry, submitted that deliberations are going on at the highest level and the government is contemplating enacting a new law.

The counsel, appearing for petitioner Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC), said that nobody should go scot-free in the absence of rules.

The bench posted the matter

for further hearing on August 10 as it took into account the verdict of August 4 last year by which it held that the pollution control boards can impose and collect as restitutionary and compensatory damages fixed sums of money or require furnishing bank guarantees as an ex-ante measure towards potential environmental damage in the exercise of powers

under Sections 33A and 31A of the Water and Air Acts.

On August 4 last year, the bench said the power to impose or collect restitutionary or compensatory damages or the requirement to furnish bank guarantees as an ex-ante measure under Sections 33A and 31A of the Water and Air Acts shall be enforced only after detailing the princi-

ple and procedure incorporating basic principles of natural justice in the subordinate legislation.

The top court had said that given their broad statutory mandate and the significant duty towards public health and environmental protection, the pollution control boards must have the power and discretion to decide the appropriate action against a polluting entity. "It is essential that the Boards function effectively and efficiently by adopting such measures as are necessary in a given situation. The Boards can decide whether a polluting entity needs to be punished by imposition of a penalty or if the situation demands immediate restoration of the environmental damage by the polluter or both," the top court had said last year.

CLOSER LOOK

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‘Constitution not privilege of few cosmopolitans’: CJI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Thursday said the Constitution belongs to all citizens equally and is not a privilege of a few cosmopolitans who can afford cost-bearing processes and engage the best of the brains.

The comments from CJI came in a speech at the launch of senior advocate Indira Jaising's memoir "The Constitution Is My Home: Conversations on a Life in Law".

The CJI, who was invited as the chief guest, could not attend the event and sent a video clip extending his warm greetings for the book launch and expressed his regret for not being present due to an upcoming meeting of BRICS judges.

"The Constitution is truly our shared home. It belongs not to judges alone, nor to law-



yers, State or public authorities. It belongs equally to every citizen, be it an urbanite or a ruralite, or the poorest of the poor, or the marginalised, who seek justice within its framework and place faith in its promises. "The Constitution is not a privilege of a few cosmopolitans who can afford cost-bearing processes and engage the best of the brains to assert something which our Constitution never intended to offer," the CJI said.

He said the Constitution is not simply a legal text govern-

ing society from a distance but is also a constant presence.

"It accompanies us in courtrooms and chambers, in arguments and deliberations. But its reach extends far beyond formal legal spaces and its influence is ultimately measured in the lives of citizens and in the character of our democracy," he said.

Observing that constitutionalism is concerned with preserving coherence between authority and principle, the CJI said public institutions function best when power and responsibility are exercised in a spirit of balance, accountability, transparency and fidelity to foundational values.

"It is this continuing commitment that allows a democratic society to respond to changing circumstances while preserving the ethos and ideals that sustain it," he said.

From Page 1 DG to MPs

More than 22.7 lakh candidates had registered for the test, and over 22.05 lakh sat for it. Four days after the exam, on May 7, the agency received information about possible malpractice. Those inputs were passed on to central agencies the following morning for independent verification. Based on findings shared by law enforcement, the decision was taken to cancel NEET-UG 2026 and schedule a fresh examination for June 21.

On the reform measures, Singh told the committee that around 70 per cent of the short-term steps recommended by the Radhakrishnan Committee have already been put in place. The NTA said it is working toward a more secure examination system and that people with credible backgrounds should be involved in setting and distributing question papers. One of the bigger changes being considered is moving NEET away from pen and paper and toward a computer-based testing platform. The NTA officials said this shift is under active consideration for future exams. Longer-term plans include multi-session and multi-stage testing formats, limits on the number of attempts and age caps, and the use of cloud-based infrastructure. The agency also intends to bring examination software in-house rather than relying on outside agencies, and is looking at integrating artificial intelligence and blockchain technology for secure monitoring. It also plans to study practices used by international testing organisations, including methods used by the Educational Testing Service. MPs at the meeting also raised concerns about staffing within the NTA. The agency acknowledged that it currently faces a shortage of around 25 per cent of its required staff and said steps are being taken to fill those vacancies in a systematic way.

On examination security, NTA officials told the panel that standard operating procedures and checklists for managing breaches have been shared with stakeholders for both paper-based and computer-based modes. The agency said it is working with state and district administrations on conducting high-stakes exams and that social media platforms are being monitored for suspicious activity.

After the meeting, panel chairperson and Congress MP Digvijaya Singh declined to go into specifics of what was discussed, citing the confidential nature of parliamentary committee proceedings. "Whatever discussions happen in the parliamentary committee, we are under oath and we cannot discuss it," he said. He later added, "The meeting went off very well. We got inputs from all the members. The members expressed their concerns over the NEET paper leak."

The cancellation of NEET-UG 2026 has renewed public concern about the reliability of one of the country's most competitive entrance examinations, which determines admission to medical colleges across India. With the re-test scheduled for June 21, the pressure is on the NTA to show that the steps it has outlined will hold up in practice.

Take steps

He also directed ministries to ensure people receive the full benefits of welfare programmes and that

government work does not remain pending. Sources said the prime minister urged ministers to focus on future achievements rather than past accomplishments, noting that while the government has been in office since 2014, the focus in 2026 must remain on upcoming goals.

The ongoing conflict in West Asia also figured prominently in discussions. Modi is learnt to have asked ministries to prepare for possible economic fallout and ensure "minimum inconvenience to citizens". Areas identified for close attention included energy, agriculture, fertilisers, aviation, shipping and logistics.

A high-level informal group of ministers led by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh is already tracking developments linked to the crisis. Singh did not attend the meeting due to an official visit to South Korea, while Health Minister JP Nadda was in Geneva.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar briefed ministers on Modi's recently concluded five-nation tour covering the United Arab Emirates, the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy, outlining diplomatic and strategic outcomes.

During the UAE leg, India signed agreements related to strategic petroleum reserves, long-term LPG supply, defence and shipping, while Abu Dhabi announced investment commitments worth USD 5 billion. In the Netherlands, India signed 17 agreements and elevated ties to a strategic partnership.

Sweden and Norway expanded cooperation in clean energy, innovation, defence, digital technologies and critical minerals through broader Nordic engagement.

In Italy, bilateral relations were upgraded to a special strategic partnership after talks with Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni.

Nine ministries presented performance reviews and future plans during the meeting, while Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan and NITI Aayog member Rajiv Gauba also made presentations. Sources said ministries with faster file disposal rates were noted as examples of efficient governance.

The meeting came shortly after the BJP's electoral success in West Bengal and Assam, with sources saying Modi was also felicitated for both the party's performance and his diplomatic outreach.

India steps up Ebola

country's preparedness to respond to a possible case. States and Union territories were advised to ensure readiness at all levels. The meeting covered coordinated surveillance, timely reporting and the preparedness of designated health facilities across the country. Health ministry officials were clear that no Ebola case has been detected in India so far. "There is no cause for panic," official sources stated, while asking citizens to follow advisories issued by health authorities. The government said it is "fully vigilant and prepared to respond swiftly to any emerging situation".

Standard operating procedures covering pre-arrival and post-arrival screening, quarantine protocols, case management, referral mechanisms and laboratory testing have already been shared with all states and Union territories. All concerned ministries and departments have also been brought up to speed and are carrying out preventive and surveillance measures in coordination with the health ministry.

India has handled situations like

this before. During the 2014 Ebola outbreak in Africa, the government had put similar precautionary measures in place and managed the situation without any domestic cases being reported.

The Ebola outbreak, centred in the DRC, has so far killed over 136 people and prompted the WHO to declare it a Public Health Emergency of International Concern, a designation that triggers international coordination and heightened response measures across member states.

The outbreak has also had a direct diplomatic impact. India and the African Union have jointly decided to postpone the Fourth India-Africa Forum Summit, which had been planned for May 28 to 31 in New Delhi. The Ministry of External Affairs said on Thursday that new dates would be worked out through consultations with African nations, though it did not spell out the reasons for the postponement in its statement. The summit had been intended to reshape and strengthen India's ties with the African continent, with top leaders from several African countries having already confirmed attendance. The last such summit was held in New Delhi in October 2015, making this gathering one of the most significant diplomatic events between the two sides in a decade.

The MEA said that India and the African Union exchanged views on the "evolving health situation" in parts of Africa and reaffirmed the importance of continued cooperation in building public health preparedness and response capacity across the continent, including through support to Africa CDC and relevant national institutions. Africa CDC is the continental autonomous health agency of the African Union. India also said it stands in solidarity with the people and governments of Africa and is ready to contribute to Africa CDC-led efforts to address the outbreak.

"Following these consultations, the two sides agreed that it would be advisable to convene the Fourth India-Africa Forum Summit at a later date," the MEA said.

India has been deepening its presence on the African continent in recent years, opening 17 new diplomatic missions since 2018, bringing its total number of missions in Africa to 46.

Heatwave

A red warning is the highest weather alert category, indicating immediate action is needed.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath directed officials to remain fully alert regarding relief and rescue measures as temperatures continued to rise.

Meteorologists in Lucknow said the extreme conditions were driven by the absence of any active weather system, clear skies causing stronger radiational heating, dry weather, and hot winds linked to an anticyclone over central India in the middle levels of the atmosphere.

Neighbouring Haryana and Punjab also faced severe heat. Faridkot in Punjab recorded 45.9 degrees Celsius, while Sirsa in Haryana touched 45.8 degrees.

Chandigarh recorded 44.2 degrees Celsius, more than four degrees above normal. In Haryana, Rohtak reached 45.5 degrees, Ambala 44.2 degrees, Hisar 44.3 degrees, Karnal 43.8 degrees, Bhiwani 44 degrees, and Gurugram 42 degrees.

Punjab remained equally affected, with Bathinda at 45.6 degrees, Patiala at 44.9 degrees, Ludhiana at 43 degrees, and Amritsar at 41.5 degrees.

In Rajasthan, Sri Ganganagar recorded 45.1 degrees Celsius, while Phalodi reached 44.8 degrees. Pilani and Alwar both touched 44 degrees. Chittorgarh recorded 43.8 degrees, Barmer 43.6 degrees, and Churu 43.4 degrees.

Himachal Pradesh also saw heat wave conditions, with temperatures staying three to five degrees above normal. Una recorded 44.3 degrees, Neri 41 degrees, and Sundernagar 39.9 degrees. An orange alert was issued for thunderstorms, lightning, hail and gusty winds in five districts on May 22.

In Uttarakhand, authorities advised children, elderly residents and outdoor workers to take precautions as temperatures in the plains may cross 40 degrees Celsius.

Iran and US

Iran to remove its enriched uranium. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has said the war cannot end without Iran also halting support for proxy groups and dismantling its ballistic missile programme.

Speaking at the White House on Thursday, Trump was direct about his position. "We will get it. We don't need it. We don't want it," he said. "We'll probably destroy it after we get it, but we're not going to let them have it." He also warned that the US was prepared to launch further strikes on Tehran if Iran refused a deal, while leaving open a window of "a few days" for diplomacy.

The International Atomic Energy Agency estimates Iran held 440.9 kilograms of uranium enriched to 60 per cent when nuclear facilities were struck in June 2025. IAEA chief Rafael Grossi said most of the surviving material is stored in tunnels at the Isfahan nuclear facility, with some remaining at Natanz. Iran maintains part of the stockpile serves medical and research purposes.

Despite mediation efforts led by Pakistan, talks have moved slowly. A US blockade of Iranian ports and Iran's grip on the Strait of Hormuz continue to complicate negotiations. Iranian sources noted Tehran remains suspicious the ceasefire may be temporary.

Still, one source pointed to a possible middle ground. "There are solutions like diluting the stockpile under the supervision of the International Atomic Energy Agency," the source said.

Delhi reopens

applicants through their login profiles for resubmission with updated documents, including valid income certificates.

"This is not merely an administrative reform. It is our commitment to ensuring food security and a life of dignity for every needy family in Delhi," CM Rekha Gupta said. The Chief Minister said the government carried out a comprehensive audit of the public distribution system after assuming office and identified 7,71,384 ineligible or bogus beneficiaries. Of these, 6,46,123 beneficiaries were found to be above the prescribed income limit, 95,682 had not collected ration for over a year, 6,185 were deceased persons whose names remained on records, and 23,394 beneficiaries were found taking ration benefits from multiple locations.

Following the removal of these names, nearly 7.72 lakh vacancies have become available in the system. The government said 3,72,367 applications for new ration cards and 99,501 applications for addition

of family members are currently pending and will now be processed under revised norms.

CM Gupta said the Delhi Government has implemented the Delhi Food Security Rules, 2026, under the National Food Security Act, 2013, to modernise ration distribution. Traditional weighing machines at fair-price shops are being replaced with electronic systems, while biometric authentication has been made mandatory to prevent leakages and under-weighting.

A three-tier verification mechanism has also been introduced. Applications will first be digitally scrutinised by Food and Supply Officers, followed by examination by Assistant Commissioners and final approval by district-level committees headed by District Magistrates along with two local MLAs.

The Chief Minister said the annual family income eligibility limit has already been raised from Rs.1 lakh to Rs.1.20 lakh and the government is considering increasing it further to Rs.2.50 lakh. "The discussions at the Cabinet level have been positive and a final decision is expected soon," she said.

Delhi Food and Civil Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said, "For 13 years, the rights of Delhi's poor remained effectively locked away. Previous governments turned the ration system into a vehicle for politics and corruption." He added that the government aims to create a "transparent and people-centric mechanism" to ensure benefits reach every eligible household "with dignity".

Layoffs turn

The wider technology slowdown has added to that strain. According to Layoffs.fyi, more than 110,000 employees across 144 technology companies have lost jobs so far in 2026. Immigration experts say thousands of those affected are likely H-1B holders, many of them Indian professionals.

For workers facing sudden termination, the consequences often extend far beyond employment. Mortgage payments, children's schooling, healthcare coverage and long-pending green card applications can all be thrown into uncertainty within days.

"Indian H-1B holders are taking it the hardest because their green card backlogs were already decades long; this is another door closing," Boundless Immigration chief executive Xiao Wang said. "We're hearing more people say they want to go home or move to Canada or Europe than at any point in the last decade."

Many laid-off workers are now trying to buy time by applying to switch temporarily to B-1 or B-2 visitor visas through Form I-539, a route that can allow them to remain in the US for several additional months while job hunting. Under past guidance, people on visitor status could attend interviews and search for work, provided they were not employed.

But immigration lawyers say that option has become harder to use.

"We are seeing a significant spike in RFEs and Notices of Intent to Deny on B-1/B-2 change-of-status applications filed by laid-off H-1B workers," said US immigration attorney Rajiv Khanna, referring to requests for further evidence and formal notices indicating possible rejection. He said the volume of such cases is unlike anything his team has previously handled.

Other immigration pathways are also being explored, including F-1 student visas, O-1 visas for individuals with exceptional achievements, and L-1 visas for company

transfers. Some professionals are weighing relocation to Canada through programmes such as Express Entry and the Global Talent Stream, while others are considering a return to India.

Immigration attorney Kevin J Andrews said many workers are now reassessing whether remaining in the US remains practical, especially as artificial intelligence changes hiring patterns.

The latest fears have been sharpened by developments at Meta, which has begun another round of global layoffs as it restructures around artificial intelligence. Reports indicate about 8,000 jobs have been cut, with employees in Singapore receiving layoff emails as early as 4am local time on Wednesday. Workers in the US and Europe were also expected to be affected.

In an internal memo reviewed by Bloomberg, Meta's head of people Janelle Gale said the company wants "flatter" teams that can move faster with greater ownership. The company has reportedly reassigned nearly 7,000 employees to AI-focused teams and is expected to spend more than \$100 billion on artificial intelligence this year.

Laid-off Meta employees are reported to receive 16 weeks of base pay in severance, plus two additional weeks for every year of continuous service, along with 18 months of healthcare coverage for families.

Still, financial packages do little to ease immigration uncertainty. Unlike permanent residents or green card holders, H-1B workers cannot remain indefinitely after losing employment. For many Indian professionals who spent years building careers and families in America, the challenge is no longer simply finding another job. It is finding one quickly enough to preserve the life they have built.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

‘Cockroach Janta Party’

But the takedown did little to slow the BJP's momentum. Within hours, a new X account titled "Cockroach Is Back" appeared with the defiant tagline, "Cockroaches Don't Die". By around 6 pm, the new handle had already amassed more than 39,000 followers, signalling that the BJP's digital energy remained intact despite the restriction. "This was expected since there were attempts to hack the account yesterday. But this is a self-goal by the government," Dipke said, adding that the team intended to challenge the withholding legally. "I have now started a new account named 'Cockroach Is Back' on X," he said.

The sudden rise of the movement has stunned political observers, digital strategists and even mainstream political parties. What makes the phenomenon remarkable is not merely the numbers, but the speed and social mood behind it. According to multiple reports, the movement began only days ago after controversial remarks attributed to Chief Justice Surya Kant allegedly describing sections of India's unemployed youth as "cockroaches" during a court hearing.

Dipke, who grew up in Aurangabad, studied journalism in Pune, and later worked with the Aam Aadmi Party social media ecosystem before moving to Boston for higher studies, tapped into a volatile mix of internet humour, political frustration and youth alienation. Using satire as a weapon, he launched the "Cockroach Janta Party" with a Google Form and a meme-heavy campaign mocking unemployment, exam paper leaks,

inflation and political hypocrisy.

Within 72 hours, the movement reportedly crossed one lakh sign-ups and rapidly spread across Instagram reels, meme pages and YouTube shorts. Political figures, including Mahua Moitra and Kirti Azad, publicly interacted with the movement online, further amplifying its reach.

But beneath the humour lies a deeper story about the state of political communication in India. Analysts say the rise of BJP reflects the emergence of a digitally native protest culture where memes are replacing speeches and Instagram pages are beginning to rival traditional political organisations in influence. Unlike conventional parties, the movement required no offices, rallies or cadre networks. It thrived entirely on algorithmic momentum, irony and collective frustration. The BJP, which has long dominated India's digital political ecosystem, suddenly found itself symbolically challenged by an anonymous, decentralised meme movement. Even if follower counts do not directly translate into electoral support, the optics of a satirical account overtaking the ruling party online carried undeniable political weight.

Many supporters are therefore interpreting the withholding of the X account as more than a moderation decision. Critics argue it reinforces growing anxieties around censorship, platform compliance and shrinking digital dissent spaces in India. Under India's IT regulations, social media companies can be directed to remove or restrict access to accounts through legal orders. However, no official statement explaining the precise grounds for the restriction had been issued till Thursday evening.

At the same time, some political analysts caution against romanticising the movement. They point out that viral engagement often reflects temporary emotional release rather than durable political organisation. The anonymity, humour and anti-establishment messaging that fuelled the movement may also make it difficult to sustain beyond the current wave of outrage.

Yet the larger message appears impossible to ignore. India's young internet users, burdened by unemployment, rising competition and institutional distrust, are increasingly turning to satire as a form of political participation. The Cockroach Janta Party may or may not evolve into something lasting, but its explosive rise has already exposed a changing political landscape where memes, reels and digital identity can shape public discourse faster than traditional politics ever imagined.

Ghaziabad Police

"We are identifying the people involved in the rally through CCTV footage and videos," said Masuri Station House Officer Ajay Kumar.

The original rape case dates to August 8, 2025, when an LLB student told police that Prajapati had called her to Muradnagar under the pretext of a meeting with a senior lawyer, took her to a flat, and assaulted her after she consumed a cold drink she believed was laced with intoxicants. Police say Prajapati had befriended the woman in 2021 and persuaded her to move her legal practice from Meerut to Ghaziabad with promises of professional help. After the complaint, police announced a reward of Rs 25,000 for information on his whereabouts before detaining him on August 20, 2025.

‘CONGRESS TO EXTEND FULL SUPPORT’

Vijay expands Cabinet with 23 more as Cong comes aboard TVK govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday expanded his Cabinet by inducting 23 more legislators as ministers, including two from the Congress, which marked the return of the grand old party to governance in Tamil Nadu after almost 60 years.

The swearing-in ceremony was held at the Lok Bhavan and Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office and secrecy to the minister-designates. TVK MLAs, including Srinath, S Kamali, C Vijayalakshmi and R V Ranjithkumar were initially sworn-in as ministers.

Congress party's S Rajesh Kumar, representing Killiyoor, and P Viswanathan, who won from Melur segment, took oath as ministers. AICC incharge for Tamil Nadu, Girish Chodankar, said the inclusion of his party MLAs in the Cabinet heralded a "turning point" in the political history of Tamil Nadu.

"Congress cadres have been striving for power for the last 59 years and have been working for it with loyalty and dedication. Now, they have got it," Chodankar said.

Congress Lok Sabha



Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar and CM C Joseph Vijay congratulate Congress leader P Viswanathan

TN sets up ministry for AI

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government established a dedicated ministry for Artificial Intelligence, making it the second state, after neighbouring Kerala, to create a separate ministry. TVK legislator R Kumar, who won from Velachery Assembly constituency, was administered the oath as minister by Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar here on Thursday in the presence of Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay. He has been allocated Artificial Intelligence, Information Technology and Digital Services portfolios. The move comes shortly after the Kerala government announced a similar dedicated ministry focusing on AI.

AGENCIES

(Karur) MP Jothimani said in a statement: "After 59 years, two members of the Congress party have taken up positions in the Tamil Nadu Cabinet. This is a highly joyful moment for the Congress party. Heartfelt congratulations to elder brother Viswanathan and younger brother Rajeshkumar! May this responsibility turn out to be a great opportunity to render exemplary service to the people of Tamil Nadu."

Also, Congress supporters hailed on social media the inclusion of party MLAs in the Cabinet on May 21, the

death anniversary of iconic leader Rajiv Gandhi. A total of 23 MLAs were sworn in as ministers and it includes three women. Vijay's friend Srinath, elected from Thoothukudi Assembly segment, was the first to take oath. Mohamed Farvas J, and N Marie Wilson were from the minority communities. Governor Arlekar corrected Congress leader Rajesh Kumar during his oath-taking and asked him to confine to the written oath given to him. While reading out the oath from a paper, he suddenly hailed Congress leaders Kamaraj, Rajiv Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, spontaneously prompting the Governor to say, "that is not part of your oath."

The Cabinet expansion marks the Congress' return to government in Tamil Nadu after nearly six decades as the Dravidian majors--DMK and AIADMK, have never accommodated allies.

‘Modi making reels while youth suffer’: Rahul targets PM

Escalates attack over NEET leak, says ‘govt runs on fear’

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Rahul Gandhi pays tribute on Rajiv Gandhi's death anniversary

PTI

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday launched a sharp attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the NEET-UG paper leak controversy, accusing the Centre of failing India's youth and refusing to take responsibility for repeated examination irregularities.

In a post on X, Gandhi alleged that while students across the country were protesting against paper leaks and demanding justice, the prime minister remained disconnected from their concerns. "When Modi ji was making reels while handing out candies in Italy, India's youth — distressed by paper leaks — were on the streets seeking justice," Gandhi said. He claimed the NEET-UG paper leak had jeopardised the future of lakhs of students and pushed many families into distress. He also referred to reports of students allegedly taking extreme steps

amid mounting pressure and uncertainty surrounding competitive examinations.

"Lakhs of students have seen their future ruined because of the NEET paper leak. Several young lives have been devastated. Yet Modi ji neither accepted responsibility, nor removed Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, nor even spoke a word on the issue," Gandhi said.

The Congress leader reiterated his party's demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, asserting that the Congress would continue its protests until accountability was fixed and a robust mechanism to prevent paper leaks was implemented nationwide.

anism to prevent paper leaks was implemented nationwide.

Gandhi also accused BJP governments in various states of suppressing student protests through police action. Referring to demonstrations led by the National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and Congress workers, he alleged that protesters demanding justice were being met with force instead of answers.

"A government that responds to students' questions with batons does not run on accountability; it runs on fear," he said. "But we will not be intimidated. We will continue this fight until Dharmendra Pradhan resigns and a secure system is established to stop paper leaks in the country."

Gandhi also tagged a Rajasthan Congress social media post carrying a purported video of police using water cannons to disperse protesting students and NSUI workers outside the BJP headquarters in Jaipur.

Shared cheers mark Kerala Assembly oath

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The swearing-in of members to the 16th Kerala Legislative Assembly on Thursday became more than a formal constitutional ceremony, as the House witnessed moments reflecting the state's diversity, simplicity and political culture.

While some newly elected MLAs walked to the Assembly or arrived on bicycles, others took oath in different languages and in the name of God or through solemn affirmation, adding a personal touch to the proceedings.

The day also saw political rivals setting aside the sharp exchanges of the election campaign as leaders greeted and smiled at one another after the ceremony, giving the Assembly a rare moment of warmth and camaraderie.

The swearing-in also saw



BJP MLAs V Muralaeeharan, Rajeev Chandrasekhar and BB Gopakumar and other leaders arrive on foot

PTI

Chief Minister V D Satheesan disregarding the recent criticism he faced on social media and from within the Congress for mentioning his 'caste' while taking oath as CM, and again referring to it while being sworn in as an MLA.

While taking oath as an MLA, the CM said his entire name -- Vadasseril Damodara Menon Satheesan -- as he had done on Monday while being sworn in as the chief minister.

Following the criticism, Satheesan on Wednesday, at

a press conference here after a Cabinet meeting, had defended his use of the caste surname during his swearing-in ceremony, saying he had only mentioned his father's name and saw nothing wrong in doing so on such an occasion.

The swearing-in also saw Pro-tem Speaker G Sudhakaran getting up from his seat and walking a few paces to congratulate Pinarayi Vijayan as he walked up to the dais after taking oath. The two, who had engaged in a war of words during the poll campaign after Sudhakaran chose not to renew his CPI(M) membership and contested as a UDF-backed independent candidate from Ambalapuzha constituency, greeted each other and shook hands as if nothing adverse had ever transpired between them.

AGENCIES

UP govt to make dress code mandatory in varsities & colleges

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has decided to make dress codes mandatory in universities and colleges across the state in a move aimed at promoting equality, discipline and social harmony in educational institutions.

Higher Education Minister Yogendra Upadhyay said on Thursday that the decision would be implemented on the directions of Governor Anandiben Patel. He said efforts would be made to introduce a uniform dress code in all higher educational institutions across the state.

The minister said students form a homogeneous group

Students form a homogeneous group and there should be no visible social or economic discrimination among them

and there should be no visible social or economic discrimination among them. He said differences in clothing often reflect economic inequality, leading to inferiority complex among some students and a sense of superiority among others. According to the minister, implementation of a dress code would help reduce such distinctions and create an environment where all students can study on equal footing.

The announcement is part of the Government of Uttar Pradesh's broader push to strengthen discipline and improve the academic atmosphere in educational institutions under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. Upadhyay said the government's focus was not limited to improving educational quality but also on creating a positive, disciplined and value-based environment in colleges and universities. He said the dress code would serve not only as a symbol of discipline but also as a means to strengthen social harmony and equal opportunity.

New Hathras documentary raises questions over probe

NEW DELHI: All India Mahila Congress president Alka Lamba on Thursday demanded fresh action against Uttar Pradesh Police officials involved in the 2020 Hathras gangrape case, citing a new crime documentary that alleges deliberate destruction of evidence allowed three of the four accused to walk free.

Lamba screened excerpts from Hathras 16 Days, a three-part documentary in which the gynaecologist who examined the victim says all physical evidence had been washed away before the medical examination, though her clinical assessment strongly indicated sexual assault. The victim's dying declaration naming the accused was also allegedly not presented before the court.

The documentary also features former UP Additional Director General of Police (Law and Order) Prashant Kumar, who admitted on camera that police failed to collect forensic evidence for eight days after the assault.

MPOST

Cockroach cocktail: Democracy, memes, and a matchstick

A metaphor, a meme, and the making of a political storm around CJP

Key points

- » The pain of young people is real. Unemployment, exam delays, paper leaks, and inequality of opportunity are not memes; they are national concerns. But giving pain a platform and turning pain into a firecracker to burst at the judiciary's window are two different things
- » The cockroach metaphor is not new. Against the backdrop of Stalin's paranoia and hunger for power, Korney Chukovsky's



widely read 1921 Russian poem Tarakanishche featured a moustached cockroach who ruled through fear

HITESH SHANKAR

NEW DELHI: India is a wondrous country. Here, divinity is found in stone, life in trees, a mother in the river, and a grandmother who feeds flour to ants. In such a country, if the cockroach becomes a matter of national debate, it is not a surprise; it is an opportunity for satire. But the problem is not the cockroach. The problem is: who released the cockroach into the crowd?

Chief Justice Surya Kant's courtroom remark was first projected as an attack on unemployed youth. Later, he clarified that his target was not young people, but those entering professions with fake and bogus degrees. In other words, the real issue was institutional integrity, not India's hardworking youth. But in the marketplace of politics, context is the cheapest commodity: the head of a sentence is sold separately, its torso separately, and its tail is turned into the flag of revolution.

From this severed context was born the Cockroach Janata Party. Satire in the name, mischief in the logo, Gen Z itchininess in the language, and behind it, the old grammar of digital politics. According to reports, its founder Abhijit Dipke submitted the registration form on May 16. He is studying public relations in Boston and was associated with AAP's social media team from 2020 to 2023. Within days, its Instagram followers reportedly surged from lakhs toward crores, and big claims of membership began to surface. Such a leap is, in itself, a subject for political study.

The pain of young people is real. Unemployment, exam delays, paper leaks, and inequality of opportunity are not memes; they are national concerns. But giving pain a platform and turning pain into a firecracker to burst at the judiciary's window are two different things. If this is spontaneous anger, then how are the website, manifesto, song, meme templates, and media timing so neatly arranged? And if this is an organised campaign, why is it being sold as innocent public outrage?

Here, too, one sees the old habit of anarchic politics. If a court asks questions, it is anger. If an investigating agency asks questions, it is revenge. If the Election Commission speaks, it is conspiracy. If the media asks questions, it is sold out. Criticising a judge is possible in a democracy; surrounding the court with mob-posters is politics of pressure. In May 2026, the Delhi High Court issued criminal contempt notices to Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia, and other AAP leaders over allegedly derogatory posts against Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma. This is precisely the point where meme, restraint, and institutional dignity come face to face.

The fatigue of the Left's century is visible here as well. The CPI traces its founding to the Kanpur conference of December 26, 1925. If, even after a hundred years, its only skill is to present fire as thought and disorder as people's movement, then that is history suffering a hiccup. The method is the same old one: first change the name, then inflame anger, then form squads, then

declare constitutional institutions to be villains.

The cockroach metaphor is not new. Against the backdrop of Stalin's paranoia and hunger for power, Korney Chukovsky's widely read 1921 Russian poem Tarakanishche featured a moustached cockroach who ruled through fear. In Belarus in 2020, the anti-Lukashenko "Slipper Revolution" used the same image against power. In Mao's China, the Four Pests Campaign went so far as to declare even sparrows enemies; nature answered with an explosion of pests and the tragedy of famine. History's lesson is clear: when an ideology begins to treat institutions, society, and nature as insects, eventually it is human beings who are reduced to bugs.

India's youth is not smaller than this game. He codes at night, takes exams in the morning, does internships in the afternoon, and skins politics alive by evening. India now has more than two lakh DPIIT-recognised startups; in the Global Innovation Index, India has risen from 81st place in 2015 to 38th. This is the same youth whom one side mocks as lazy, another provokes as unemployed, and yet another calls a cockroach while repackaging its old politics. So stay alert. In the land of Sanatan, even a cockroach can become a discourse — but not every cockroach is a revolution. Some are in the kitchen, some in the head, and some in the war room. The one who releases a cockroach into the crowd often turns out to be the biggest pest of all.

(The writer is the Editor of Panchajanya)

‘UMMID driving India’s precision medicine push’

NEW DELHI: Union Minister of State for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh on Thursday said India is steadily moving towards a healthcare system where diagnosis and treatment will increasingly be based on an individual's genetic profile.

Speaking at a function organised by the Department of Biotechnology at Prithvi Bhawan, Singh highlighted the progress of the UMMID (Unique Methods of Management of Inherited Disorders) initiative, aimed at improving the diagnosis and management

of inherited and rare genetic disorders.

The programme has so far screened nearly three lakh individuals through diagnostic and counselling services, with special outreach in Aspirational Districts and underserved regions. Around 30

NIDAN Kendras have also been established across the country to provide advanced genomic diagnostics and counselling services. Singh released the UMMID Compendium and launched a new UMMID Dashboard for monitoring of the programme.

MPOST

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Date: 21.05.2026
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PoK: Pulwama attack mastermind shot dead by ‘unknown’ gunmen

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Arjumand Gulzar, alias Burhan Hamza, a designated terrorist and the key mastermind behind the 2019 Pulwama terror attack on a CRPF convoy, has been shot dead by unidentified gunmen in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), officials said here on Thursday.

Hamza, who was operating under heavy ISI-vetted security, was ambushed in Muzaffarabad.

He was critically injured and airlifted to the Combined Military Hospital (CMH) in Rawalpindi, where he succumbed to his injuries, the officials said.

The assailants managed to flee the scene before local security forces could intervene, they added.

Originally from Khar in Jammu and Kashmir's Pulwama district, Hamza was once associated with Al Badr, moved to Al Baraq, and maintained a close alliance with Pakistan's espionage agency, the ISI, after an acrimonious exit from the outfit.

He was declared a designated terrorist under UAPA for his involvement in orchestrating the February 14, 2019, suicide terror attack conducted by Pakistan-based terrorist organisation Jaish-e-Mohammad, on a CRPF convoy in Pulwama, which killed 40 personnel.

In retaliation, the Indian security forces ran an intelligence-led operation led by IAF jets in the early hours of February 26, 2019, striking the biggest training camp of JeM in Balakot.

Hamza, who also had an alias, Doctor, was currently living in Cheela Bandi, a densely populated neighbourhood on



File photo of security personnel at the site of suicide attack in Pulwama in 2019

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Arjumand Gulzar alias Burhan Hamza was a designated terrorist and the key mastermind behind the 2019 Pulwama terror attack on a CRPF convoy
- » Hamza was operating under heavy ISI-vetted

security

- » He was 'critically injured and airlifted to the Combined Military Hospital in Rawalpindi, where he succumbed to his injuries'
- » The assailants managed to flee the scene before local security forces could intervene

the outskirts of Muzaffarabad, with security details of eight commandos, a bullet-resistant (BR) vehicle, and an escort vehicle, indicating state-level protection and operational importance, sources said.

The security cover was given to him after he allegedly made a fabricated attack on himself somewhere between January and February 2025, they said.

He worked closely with Farooq Qureshi, a former Al Baraq commander whose name has repeatedly surfaced in dossiers linked to narcotics trafficking, counterfeit currency rackets, arms smuggling and cross-border militant operations in the Kashmir Valley.

The two operated from an industrial compound locally

referred to as the "Machis Factory" in Muzaffarabad, the sources said.

Hamza maintained close ties with Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence, particularly with an officer identified as Col Rizwan, suggesting deeper intelligence ties and protection, they said.

The terrorist had recently married the daughter of Qadir Lala, a former Hizbul Mujahideen operative from Kupwara, currently employed as a security operator at the terror group's housing project in Chek Shezad, Pakistan.

He was also said to have maintained close ties with Murtaza, another former Hizbul Mujahideen operative from Pulwama, now based in Islamabad, making frequent visits to his residence, the sources said.

Courts can hold sedition trials if accused has no objection, says SC

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday said that courts can hear trials pertaining to section 124A of the Indian Penal Code, which relates to sedition, if the accused has no objection to it.

The clarification from a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joyimalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi came while hearing a plea by an accused who has been in jail for 17 years in a case related to sedition.

The appeal filed by the accused is pending before the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

"The petitioner's grievance is that he has no objection if his criminal appeal is heard in entirety, including with respect to the charge under Section

124A. That being so, we clarify... that wherever the accused has no objection against proceeding of the trial, appeal, or any other proceeding where he has been chargesheeted under Section 124A IPC also, there shall be no impediment for the courts to decide such matters on merits and in accordance with law", the bench said.

The top court asked the Madhya Pradesh High Court to hear the petitioner's appeal, and decide the same on merit.

In a landmark order passed on May 11, 2022, the apex court had put the penal provision on sedition on hold till the Centre completed its promised review of the colonial-era relic and also asked the Union and state governments not to register any

CBI TO SCRUTINISE THE CHAIN OF EVENTS

Calcutta High Court orders SIT probe into RG Kar rape-murder 'cover up'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court on Thursday ordered the formation of a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT), led by the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) Joint Director of the Eastern Zone, to examine allegations of a broader conspiracy and attempts to suppress facts in the RG Kar Medical College and Hospital rape-murder case.

A division bench of Justice Shampa Sarkar and Justice Tirthankar Ghosh directed the SIT to place its report before the court on June 25. The bench instructed the CBI to closely scrutinise the chain of events beginning from the victim's dinner on the night of August 9, 2024, up to the cremation of her body, while granting the agency liberty to investigate all connected aspects necessary

KEY POINTS

- » The Calcutta High Court has ordered the formation of a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) in connection with the RG Kar rape-murder case
- » The SIT will be headed by the Joint Director of the Eastern Zone of the Central Bureau of Investigation



» The court directed the SIT to investigate allegations of a larger conspiracy and attempts to suppress facts related to the case

for an effective probe.

During the hearing, the court sought details regarding the progress of the investigation after the filing of the chargesheet on October 7, 2024, questioning what steps had been taken over the last one year and seven months. In response, the CBI submit-

ted that statements of nearly 70 to 80 persons had been recorded during the course of the investigation.

The court has been hearing petitions seeking a more extensive probe into allegations that crucial evidence and material facts relating to the crime were deliberately concealed

B'luru: Air India plane experiences tail strike

NEW DELHI: An Air India aircraft, with 181 passengers onboard, suffered a tail strike during landing at the Bengaluru airport on Thursday morning and the plane has been grounded for a detailed inspection. The airline's narrow-body A321 aircraft was operating the flight AI2651 from Delhi to Bengaluru.

An Air India spokesperson said the plane "experienced a tail-strike during landing".

The aircraft landed safely, and all passengers and crew disembarked normally, the spokesperson said. A source said the plane experienced "wake turbulence" when it was close to land, following which the pilot decided to perform a go around manoeuvre. During the manoeuvre, there was a tail strike, the source added.

The "wake turbulence" was

caused due to the take-off of a wide-body aircraft in the vicinity, the source said.

Specific details about the wide-body plane could not be ascertained. The source said there were 181 passengers onboard the aircraft that operated the flight AI2651.

The Air India spokesperson said the plane has been grounded for detailed inspection and the incident will be investigated in accordance with established procedures, in coordination with the relevant regulatory authorities.

"As a result, the return flight AI2652 from Bengaluru to Delhi has been cancelled. Alternative arrangements are being made to accommodate affected passengers at the earliest. Our ground teams in Bengaluru are providing all necessary assistance," he said.

AGENCIES

Saini warns officials over delays in public work

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday warned of strict action against government officials and employees who force citizens to make repeated visits to offices for their work.

Addressing people during the 'Jan Samvad' programme at Ladwa in Kurukshetra district, Saini said the government's priority is to ensure holistic development and guarantee that welfare schemes reach every eligible beneficiary without delay. He stressed that public grievances must be addressed promptly and transparently.

The chief minister also urged citizens to mention their mobile numbers while submitting complaints so departments can directly contact them



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini during the 'Jan Samvad' programme at Ladwa in Kurukshetra

regarding grievance redressal. During the programme, Saini heard 338 grievances from local residents.

One complainant alleged that although he had purchased nearly seven acres of land in Bakali village years

ago, some persons, in connivance with an official, got electricity poles and a transformer installed on the pathway leading to his fields despite the route being recorded in ownership documents. The complainant further alleged that

exploitative occult practices and fraudulent rituals prohibited under state laws. According to the ED, Kharat projected himself as a spiritual leader and allegedly claimed to be an incarnation of Lord Shiva with supernatural powers. Investigators alleged that victims were threatened with death, black magic and misfortune, while elaborate rituals and emotional pressure were used to extort money from them.

The agency alleged that several people were persuaded to spend huge amounts in the name of "Avatar Pooja", spiritual remedies and mystical guidance. In one case, a victim allegedly spent nearly Rs 5.62 crore at Kharat's direction on a luxury Mercedes car, foreign trips, medical treatment in the US and development of farm

SIR: 20K BLOs to verify voter details in Hry

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: More than 20,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) will conduct door-to-door verification of voter details in Haryana from June 15 to July 14 as part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Haryana Chief Electoral Officer A Sreenivas said 20,629 BLOs have been appointed for the month-long exercise aimed at ensuring "pure and accurate electoral rolls".

The CEO's office has received details of 14,520 booth-level agents (BLAs) from recognised political parties, including 6,438 from BJP and 7,704 from Congress.

Sreenivas said the exercise would be conducted transparently and no pressure would be placed on officials engaged in the work. Haryana currently has 2.06 crore registered voters and 20,629 polling stations.

Twisha death case: Husband moves MP High Court for pre-arrest bail

JABALPUR: After failing to get any relief from lower court, Samarth Singh, the absconding husband of Twisha Sharma who was allegedly harassed for dowry and died last week, has filed an anticipatory bail application in the Madhya Pradesh High Court claiming that his family was cooperating with the investigation team and that there was no need for custodial interrogation.

In a Miscellaneous Criminal Case (MCCR) filed before a single bench by his brother Siddharth Singh, the petitioner claimed that the entire prosecution story had been constructed and built "on imagination and presumptions" and that every substantial material had already been seized.

The applicant, who has been on the run ever since the case was registered by the Madhya Pradesh Police, claimed in his 69-page petition that he and his mother have been cooperating in the investigation till today.

The absconding accused moved the High Court after a magistrate court had earlier rejected his anticipatory bail application while granting it to his mother, Giribala Singh, a retired district sessions judge. She is also named in the FIR registered in the case.

Twisha Sharma was found hanging at her marital home in Bhopal's Katara Hills area on May 12. The family of the 33-year-old model turned actor accused her in-laws of pushing her daughter to death. The Singhs claim she was addicted to drugs.

Police registered an FIR under Sections 80(2), 85, and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita along with relevant sections of the Dowry Prohibition Act, naming Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh.

Police have announced a cash reward for information leading to Samarth Singh's arrest and also approached the court for the revocation of his passport.

AGENCIES

Railways to enhance passenger safety with AI, CCTV & drone surveillance

Vaishnaw terms recent mishaps an 'intentional target on railways'

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Following a couple of mishaps this year and major railway accidents reported last year, the Railways ministry has decided to bolster passenger safety and security by deploying advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI), drones and upgraded CCTV surveillance systems across the network.

Railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw termed the incidents an "intentional target on railways". After a high-level review meeting held at Rail Bhawan on Thursday, officials said the enhanced safety measures would be implemented in mission mode throughout the railway network.

Officials have also been directed to strengthen intelligence gathering at the beat level of the Railway Protection Force (RPF). According to an official statement, extensive consultations were held with field officers from across the country in the presence of senior railway officials. The meeting was chaired by Vaishnaw and attended by Ministers of State for Railways

KEY POINTS

- » Railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw chairs a high-level meeting at Rail Bhawan on Thursday
- » After the meeting, officials said the enhanced safety measures would be implemented in mission mode throughout the railway network



» Preliminary probe into several recent incidents, including fire-related cases, pointed towards the involvement of anti-social elements

V. Somanna and Ravneet Singh Bittu, along with the Chairman of the Railway Board.

Railway officials said preliminary investigations into several recent incidents, including fire-related cases, pointed towards the involvement of anti-social elements. "Indian Railways has taken these incidents seriously, and the RPF is actively probing them. In several cases, timely and proactive action by railway staff helped avert major mishaps," an official communicated.

Passengers have been urged to remain vigilant and imme-

diately report any suspicious person or activity on railway premises through the railway helpline number 139.

The meeting also focused on improving operational coordination between Railway Board headquarters and field zones, strengthening cyber security, upgrading surveillance camera systems and deploying AI-based monitoring tools. Enhanced coordination and information-sharing between the RPF and Government Railway Police were also emphasised to ensure more effective security management.

BSF's first all-women team scales Mt Everest

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Border Security Force (BSF) scripted history as its first all-women mountaineering team successfully scaled Mount Everest under "Mission Vande Mataram", marking a major milestone during the force's Diamond Jubilee celebrations.

The four-member team — M/Ct Kouser Fatima from Ladakh, M/Ct Munmun Ghosh from West Bengal, M/Ct Rabeka Singh from Uttarakhand and M/Ct Tsering Choral from Kargil — reached the summit of the world's highest peak, Mount Everest (8,848.86 metres), at around 8 am (IST).

The expedition commemorated 60 years of the BSF and 150 years of "Vande Mataram", India's national song. Officials described the achievement as a landmark moment for the force and a symbol of the growing role of women in uniformed services.

At the summit, the BSF women climbers played "Vande Mataram", a gesture officials termed deeply symbolic and patriotic. Battling extreme weather and thin air, the team



completed the challenging ascent after months of rigorous preparation and training.

The expedition was formally launched from New Delhi on April 6. Officials said the mission drew inspiration from the government's emphasis on women empowerment and was encouraged by messages from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah throughout the journey.

Apart from the mountaineering feat, the team will also contribute to environmental conservation efforts under the "Clean Himalaya - Clean Glaciers" campaign. BSF climbers will bring down nearly 500 kg of waste from the Everest region, which will be transported to Namche Bazaar for proper disposal.



EDITORIAL
DEEPENING
CRISIS

For years, the Indian rupee's gradual depreciation was treated almost as an economic inevitability — a manageable symptom of a developing economy dependent on imports and global capital. But what India is witnessing today is no ordinary currency fluctuation. The rupee's sharp slide towards the psychologically dangerous 100-per-dollar mark is emerging as a warning signal that policymakers can no longer afford to dismiss as temporary volatility. Beneath the falling exchange rate lies a far deeper story about India's structural vulnerabilities, its dependence on imported energy, the fragility of global capital flows, and the dangerous economic consequences of a world entering a prolonged phase of geopolitical instability. The immediate trigger behind the rupee's collapse is clear. The escalation of tensions in West Asia, particularly around Iran and disruptions near the Strait of Hormuz, has once again exposed India's Achilles' heel — oil dependence. India imports more than 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements. Every spike in crude prices, therefore, translates directly into higher dollar demand, widening trade deficits and immense pressure on the rupee. When Brent crude climbs towards USD 110 per barrel, India's import bill explodes almost overnight. April's crude import expenditure of USD 18.7 billion offers only a glimpse of the stress that could intensify if geopolitical tensions continue.

Unlike commodity-exporting economies that benefit during periods of high global prices, India pays the price for every global disruption. And this time, the problem is compounded by a strengthening US dollar and aggressive foreign portfolio outflows. Global investors are retreating from emerging markets and shifting capital into safer American assets as geopolitical uncertainty rises and US interest rates remain elevated. India, despite its growth narrative, has not been spared. Foreign investors have already withdrawn over USD 23 billion from Indian equities this year — a figure that has surpassed last year's total outflows. That withdrawal is not merely affecting stock markets; it is draining dollar liquidity from the economy itself. The consequences are now spreading across every layer of Indian economic life. A weaker rupee immediately makes imports costlier — not just oil, but fertilisers, edible oils, machinery, chemicals, electronics and industrial raw materials. Inflationary pressures become unavoidable. Fuel prices rise. Transport costs increase. Food prices begin reacting. Manufacturing input costs climb. Imported education, overseas travel and medical treatment have become more expensive for ordinary Indians. The ripple effects eventually reach every household.

This is where the current crisis becomes particularly dangerous. India is now confronting the possibility of imported inflation at a time when domestic demand remains uneven and global growth itself is slowing. That combination creates the risk of a stagflationary environment — slowing economic momentum accompanied by rising prices — one of the most difficult situations for any government or central bank to manage. The Reserve Bank of India has attempted to contain the damage through repeated interventions in currency markets, selling dollars from foreign exchange reserves to slow the rupee's fall. But there are limits to what intervention can achieve. Foreign exchange reserves are not infinite, and no central bank can permanently defend a currency when the underlying pressures are structural. RBI intervention can smooth volatility, but it cannot reverse the realities of expensive oil, widening trade deficits and sustained capital outflows. More importantly, the falling rupee is exposing uncomfortable truths about India's economic model. For years, India celebrated its emergence as a major global economy while remaining critically dependent on imported energy and volatile foreign capital. The economy expanded, consumption rose, and infrastructure spending accelerated, but India never fundamentally reduced its vulnerability to external shocks. The current crisis is a reminder that geopolitical instability thousands of kilometres away can still destabilise India's financial system within days.

There is another worrying dimension policymakers must confront honestly. Markets are beginning to sense that India's macroeconomic resilience is weakening under pressure. Rising current account deficits, expensive imports and persistent outflows are feeding expectations of further depreciation. Once markets begin pricing in continued weakness, currency declines can become self-reinforcing. Importers rush to buy dollars early. Investors hedge aggressively. Speculative pressure builds. Confidence erodes. The psychological aspect of currency stability matters enormously. A rupee approaching 100 per dollar would not merely be symbolic; it would signal globally that India is entering a period of heightened financial stress. Investor confidence, business sentiment and household expectations would all be affected.

Yet the answer cannot simply be short-term fire-fighting. India requires a deeper strategic response. Reducing long-term oil dependence is no longer merely an environmental objective; it is now a national economic security imperative. Faster expansion of renewable energy, domestic manufacturing capacity, strategic petroleum reserves and export competitiveness must become central pillars of policy. Equally important is reducing excessive dependence on volatile foreign portfolio flows by strengthening domestic capital formation. There are, admittedly, limited short-term benefits to a weaker rupee. Exporters earn more in rupee terms, and remittances from Indians abroad become more valuable. But these advantages are unlikely to offset the broader inflationary shock facing a heavily import-dependent economy like India's. The rupee's fall is not merely a currency story. It is a mirror reflecting the vulnerabilities of an economy navigating an increasingly unstable world. India now faces a defining test: whether it can transform this crisis into an opportunity for structural correction, or whether it will continue reacting each time global turbulence defensively exposes the same old fault lines again.

CONCRETE
JUNGLES



KDP RAO

THE WRITER
IS A FORMER
ADDITIONAL CHIEF
SECRETARY OF
CHHATTISGARH

Master plans
need to be
shaped by long-
term political
vision, envisaging
multifunctionality,
community and
private sector
involvement
and innovation

India's Shrinking Urban Greens

As Indian cities expand rapidly, shrinking parks and open spaces are affecting public health, children's development, climate resilience and the overall quality of urban life

Parks and open spaces are essential for physical health, mental well-being, and the overall quality of urban life. They foster interaction among people across sociocultural backgrounds and help promote a progressive outlook. Children frolicking on the lawns, birds singing on the trees, and aged people relaxing on benches enjoying the cool evening breeze, were once common sights in parks, as seen in Bollywood movies of the 1960s and 1970s. Now, it is only a luxury, as there is a noticeable dearth of designated parks and open squares. Swarming crowds of morning walkers squeezing into the limited space of poorly maintained municipal parks are a common feature of most cities today. Some are even forced to take long walks on streets or highways, risking unexpected attacks from stray dogs or bike-borne thieves. Worse still, children play on streets and busy roads, as nearly half of urban schools do not have playgrounds and exclusive children's parks are almost non-existent.

In our exuberance to build cities as 'centres of excellence', perhaps we have compromised the need for robust mental health by underplaying the importance of proper green breathing spaces and open public recreation zones. The World Health Organisation (WHO) suggests a minimum of 9 m² of green space per person, while India's Urban and Regional Development Plans Formulation and Implementation (URDPFI) guidelines ambitiously recommend 10–12 m². But in reality, while Mumbai has as little as 1.08 m² of accessible open space per person, Chennai and some other cities have even less (0.46–0.81 m²). Bengaluru, of course, has around 3–17 m² per person, but the distribution is highly uneven, with many city wards having zero or just one park.

Studies have shown an inverse relationship between proximity to parks and symptoms of depression, stress, anxiety, and isolation. Without outdoor play, experts say, children may develop issues related to cognitive growth, imagination, and connection to nature,



Parks and water bodies are no longer luxuries but necessities for healthier and more resilient cities

resulting in slower emotional maturity and reduced problem-solving abilities. Children in congested neighbourhoods bear the brunt the most, as they grow up in "lost playgrounds", which take away their right to play and develop fully — a mandate of the UN Child Rights Convention.

A paper by Greta K Martin et al. published in *The Lancet* (April 2025) found that uniformly increasing greenspace by 1 per cent yielded an estimated 96-city median of 1.77 (range 0.65–3.52, IQR 1.46–2.19) fewer annual premature deaths per 100,000 population. On the other hand, increasing the population percentage with nearby natural space yielded an estimated median of 0.56 (range 0.11–1.70, IQR 0.44–0.69) fewer annual premature deaths per 100,000 population. The research concluded that, on average, compared with uniform increases, adding greenspace in the least natural areas provided 1.4–1.7 times the health benefits, while adding greenspace in the most populated areas provided 2.7 times the health benefits.

The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) have rolled out several national and state-level schemes for creating more parks, open spaces, green cover, and urban forests. For example, Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT 1.0) renovated about 1,800 parks across 475 cities, benefiting around 40 million residents. Under AMRUT 2.0, the target is the development of over 2,500 new parks and urban forests in 500 cities. There are hundreds of other projects, both central and state, including many in convergence with Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Urban (PMAY-U), Swachh Bharat Mission, and NMSH, involving significant investments. But the results are mixed.

Though notable progress is visible in targeted interventions, the overall impact on per capita green space remains limited. Even as existing parks and green belts are in need of proper maintenance, the new projects are not

commensurate with population growth. Rejuvenation work has been undertaken through the creation of lakefronts, thematic parks, green corridors, etc., but the distribution betrays a classist bias, as affluent areas benefit more than those inhabited by low-income groups. Moreover, the Smart Cities Mission suffers from ecological oversights involving the loss of wetlands and trees. Convergence models are theoretically sound, but in reality, monitoring and follow-up have been weak with regard to open space protection as envisaged in master plans.

There are successful models elsewhere based on low-cost, nature-based solutions serving the dual purpose of monsoon flood control and the creation of playgrounds and parks. The Superblocks (Superilles) model of Spain reorganises the grid into "superblocks" — grouping 3x3 or 9 blocks where interior streets prioritise pedestrians, cyclists, and greenery over through-traffic. Without needing new land, the climate action-driven model converted former roads into plazas, play areas, green corridors ("green axes"), and benches, encouraging social interaction, physical activity, and biodiversity. Denmark integrated cycling (about 50 per cent of commuters) with green spaces, creating parks, green corridors, and designs featuring sunken lawns and reservoirs where green areas manage stormwater, such as Enghaveparken. The "Five Finger Plan" guided growth along green wedges, and the model was human-centric, focusing on low-carbon urbanism. The results include high resident happiness, better health metrics, and reduced emissions.

Melbourne focuses on counteracting urban heat through the creation of regional parks, conservation reserves, greening buildings, transport corridors, and "15-minute city" principles for accessible green space. On the principle of equity, Bogotá prioritised access through Ciclovía (car-free streets) and by integrating green spaces with social programmes. Often called the "ecological capital of Brazil", Curitiba followed a 1968 mas-

ter plan that placed people and nature above unchecked growth. High per capita green space rose dramatically to about 51–60 m² per person, far above WHO standards. Parks doubled as flood control systems, recreational areas, and biodiversity zones, improving livability and social inclusion through accessible public spaces.

The nearest example is Singapore, which transformed from a tropical concrete hub into a global benchmark for urban greening through long-term vision and strict enforcement under Lee Kuan Yew. The "Garden City" campaign emphasised tree planting along roads, creating park connectors (a 370+ km network linking green spaces), and mandating greenery in developments. It later evolved into the "City in Nature" vision, aimed at restoring biodiversity while maintaining high density. The results have been remarkable, with about 47 per cent green cover, improved air quality, biodiversity, urban cooling, and enhanced resident well-being. It also attracted investment and tourism while tackling heat and flooding.

Parks, squares, and water bodies are no longer a luxury but a basic necessity to make urban life healthier, more livable, and resilient. Some of the above models have proved that, even with fewer resources, tangible environmental outcomes can be achieved through integrated climate action. India can draw inspiration from these experiments and prepare area-specific blueprints suited to local agro-climatic conditions and sociocultural needs. Master plans need to be shaped by long-term political vision, envisaging multifunctionality, community and private sector involvement and innovation. Strict compliance with URDPFI guidelines and protection of existing open grounds from 'land sharks' are immediate priorities necessary to support the entire ecosystem of green urban development. Equity, as a principle, should also be adhered to in order to promote inclusion through community ownership.

Views expressed are personal

REGIONAL
FRACTURES



ASIF ULLAH KHAN

THE WRITER
HAS WORKED IN
SENIOR EDITORIAL
POSITIONS FOR
MANY RENOWNED
INTERNATIONAL
PUBLICATIONS

The Gulf may
now be entering
an era where
competition
for leadership
overlaps with
the Iran-Israel
confrontation

A New Gulf War?

As the UAE deepens ties with Israel and the US, new tensions are reshaping Gulf geopolitics and exposing deeper rivalries with Saudi Arabia

The Middle East is entering a dangerous new phase — not simply a confrontation between Iran and the US-Israel alliance, but an emerging struggle over who will dominate the Gulf order itself.

For years, the UAE presented itself as a pragmatic commercial state focused on trade, finance, logistics, and global connectivity. Its strength came from stability, neutrality, and economic openness. But today, the UAE is no longer behaving like a cautious Gulf intermediary. It is increasingly projecting itself as an assertive military and geopolitical power, backed by close strategic coordination with the United States and Israel.

That transformation is reshaping the region. Recent reports of the UAE involvement in covert strikes against Iranian targets, expanding security cooperation with Israel, and growing integration into Western military architecture suggest that Abu Dhabi no longer sees itself merely as a protected Gulf monarchy. It now appears determined to shape the regional balance of power directly.

But in doing so, the UAE may be opening two fronts simultaneously — one against Iran — and another, more subtle one, against Saudi Arabia.

British geopolitical analyst Sami Hamdi has argued that the "new Gulf war" is increasingly not just about Iran versus the Gulf monarchies, but about a growing rivalry between Abu Dhabi and Riyadh over leadership of the Arab world and the future regional order.

That argument once sounded exaggerated. It no longer does.

The old Gulf hierarchy was relatively clear: Saudi Arabia stood as the undisputed political heavyweight of the Arab Gulf, while the UAE functioned as an ambitious yet ultimately junior partner operating within Riyadh's shadow. Today, however, that balance is shifting. The UAE is increasingly positioning itself as an independent regional power, challenging Saudi primacy across mul-



Behind the Iran-Israel confrontation lies another emerging struggle — a quiet contest between Abu Dhabi and Riyadh for regional leadership

tiples fronts — from military influence and regional alliances to energy policy, Red Sea strategy, logistics networks, and especially its expanding relationship with Israel.

While Saudi Arabia has attempted a careful balancing strategy — maintaining ties with Washington while reopening diplomatic channels with Tehran and diversifying relations with China and other powers — the UAE has moved more decisively into the US-Israel strategic orbit.

This difference reflects two competing visions for the Gulf.

Saudi Arabia appears to favour cautious regional management aimed at preserving long-term stability and protecting its economic transformation agenda under Vision 2030. Riyadh understands that a large-scale regional war could devastate energy markets, frighten investors, and derail its ambitions to become a global investment and tourism hub.

The UAE, by contrast, increasingly appears willing to convert economic power into geopolitical influence. From Yemen to Sudan, from the Horn of

Africa to the Eastern Mediterranean, Abu Dhabi has demonstrated a readiness to project force, support proxies, and shape outcomes beyond its borders. Its growing military confidence is fuelled by advanced Western weapons, intelligence coordination, sophisticated surveillance systems, and unprecedented normalisation with Israel.

But this strategy comes with immense risks.

The UAE's leadership may believe that integration into a US-Israel security architecture strengthens deterrence. Yet deterrence cuts both ways. The more the UAE becomes identified as a strategic pillar of American and Israeli regional policy, the more it transforms itself into a direct target for Iranian retaliation.

And unlike Iran, Saudi Arabia, or Israel, the UAE's greatest vulnerability is psychological and economic.

Dubai and Abu Dhabi thrive not because they are military fortresses, but because they are perceived as safe havens in a turbulent region. Their prosperity is built on confidence — the confidence of investors, multinational

corporations, tourists, expatriates, and global financial markets that the UAE remains insulated from the instability surrounding it.

Missiles and drones not only damage infrastructure. They damage perception.

Every strike near an airport, port, energy facility, or nuclear installation chips away at the image the UAE spent decades building — the image of a Gulf sanctuary untouched by regional chaos.

This is where the emerging Saudi-UAE rivalry becomes critical. Saudi Arabia may ultimately view the UAE's growing military activism and closeness with Israel not only as risky but as destabilising for the Gulf itself. Riyadh understands that if the Gulf becomes the central battlefield of a US-Iran-Israel confrontation, every state in the region will pay the price.

The recent tensions between Saudi Arabia and the UAE over Yemen, energy policy, Red Sea influence, and regional alliances already reveal deeper fractures beneath the surface of Gulf unity.

The emerging divide is therefore not merely ideological. It is strategic.

Saudi Arabia seeks to remain the indispensable center of the Arab and Islamic world while avoiding uncontrolled regional escalation.

The UAE seeks to emerge as an independent middle power capable of projecting influence far beyond its size. These ambitions are increasingly colliding. The danger is that the Gulf may now be entering an era where the competition for regional leadership overlaps with a wider Iran-Israel confrontation. In that environment, the UAE risks becoming overexposed — militarily, economically, and politically.

For decades, the Emirates mastered the art of benefiting from instability around it without becoming consumed by it. The question now is whether its new assertiveness has pushed it too close to the fire.

Views expressed are personal

ALMOST 20 TONS OF AID HAVE BEEN AIRLIFTED TO BUNIA

Ebola outbreak: Appeals in Congo for more aid supplies

BUNIA: Healthcare workers and aid groups in eastern Congo said Thursday they are in dire need of more supplies and staff to respond to the rare Ebola outbreak, as armed groups continue to threaten the safety of a region already grappling with displacement and a humanitarian crisis.

"The situation is worrying because this is gaining momentum," Hama Amado, the Bunia field coordinator for Alima, an aid group, told The Associated Press. "This is spreading in many areas. So everyone must mobilise."

He added: "We are still far from saying that the situation is under control."

There is no available vaccine or medicine for the Bundibugyo strain, which spread undetected for weeks following the first known death, while authorities tested for another, more common, Ebola virus and came up negative.

Healthcare workers and aid groups are now playing a catch-up game with an outbreak that experts say is much larger than what has been officially reported. So far, there are 139 suspected deaths and almost 600 suspected cases.

The World Health Organisation, which noted a low risk globally, has said "patient zero" has not been found.

While almost 20 tons of aid have been airlifted to Bunia, the site of the first known death, doctors using out-of-date facemasks were tending



People in protective masks wait in the corridor of a hospital in Bunia

AP/PTI

to suspected Ebola patients in general wards because of the lack of isolation space.

Early detection of the virus is key in saving lives, but the region's already weak health infrastructure and surveillance capacity have been further weakened by international aid cuts, experts say.

There are over 920,000 internally displaced people in Ituri, a province that has become the hot spot of the outbreak, according to the U.N.

"Communities in eastern DRC are already facing immense pressure from conflict, displacement, and a collapsing health system," said Dr

Highlights

- » There is no available vaccine or medicine for the Bundibugyo strain
- » Early detection of virus is key in saving lives
- » Healthcare workers in protective gear handled the bodies of suspected Ebola victims

Lievon Bangali, Senior Health Coordinator for the International Rescue Committee in DRC. "Years of underfunding, compounded by recent cuts to front-line health

and outbreak preparedness programming, have weakened the ability to detect and respond to outbreaks quickly,"

The group said it had to stop its surveillance activities in three out of five areas in Ituri over the last year because of funding cuts.

At a treatment centre in Rwampara, healthcare workers in protective gear handled the bodies of suspected Ebola victims.

Families who tend to wash loved ones' bodies themselves watched on as workers disinfected the corpses and placed them into coffins to be taken to secure burial sites. AGENCIES

Right to strike protected by key labour treaty: UN top court

THE HAGUE: The United Nations' top court issued a landmark advisory opinion on the right to strike on Thursday, finding that a cornerstone labour treaty protects the ability of workers to walk off the job.

The International Court of Justice was asked in 2023 by the International Labour Organisation, a UN agency, to settle an internal dispute over whether one of the ILO's conventions gives workers the right to strike. Advisory opinions aren't legally binding but carry significant weight. The decision could have a worldwide impact on labour regulations, enshrining the right to strike in labour standards and international trade agreements.

The convention has been ratified by 158 countries and is incorporated into UN labour standards, guidelines from the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development and international trade agreements. AGENCIES

Taliban's new marriage separation decree draws criticism from UN

KABUL: The United Nations expressed "grave concern" Thursday about a new law issued by Afghanistan's Taliban government on separation in marriage which includes provisions on child marriage, saying the code further entrenches discrimination against women and girls.

The government rejected the accusations, saying the decree follows Islamic law.

Afghanistan's justice ministry published Decree No 18 "on judicial separation of spouses" last week, setting out rules for separation of a married couple. AGENCIES

Israel begins deporting hundreds of flotilla activists

TEL AVIV: Israel has released hundreds of activists who attempted to breach Israel's naval blockade of Gaza and is in the process of deporting them, according to a legal organisation working with the flotilla.

The Israel-based legal advocacy group, the Legal Centre for Arab Minority Rights in Israel, or Adalah, said Thursday that all of the international activists are in transit to a civilian airport near the southern Israeli city of Eilat for deportation.

The group said one participant, Zohar Regev, who holds Israeli citizenship, was in a court hearing in the southern city of Ashkelon on charges of illegal entry into Israel and unlawful stay. Regev has taken part in previous flotillas to Gaza.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Wednesday he instructed that the activists be deported "as soon as possible," after sharply rebuking Israel's national security minister for a provocative video showing the minister taunting



Israeli naval forces sail a confiscated Gaza-bound flotilla boat into Israel's Ashdod port

AP/PTI

detailed flotilla activists who were handcuffed and kneeling.

Netanyahu said that although Israel has every right to stop "provocative flotillas of Hamas terrorist supporters," the way National Security Minister Itamar Ben-Gvir dealt with the activists was "not in line with Israel's values and norms."

Ben-Gvir released videos on Wednesday showing him walking among some of the

approximately 430 detainees. In one, activists with their hands tied behind their backs are kneeling, their heads touching the floor inside what appears to be a makeshift detention area on the deck of a ship.

Several countries, including France and Portugal, summoned Israeli envoys on Thursday over concerns about the treatment of flotilla activists and in protest of Ben-Gvir's actions. AGENCIES

DISCUSSES US-IRAN TALKS

Pak's interior min meets Iranian FM Araghchi

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan's Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi met Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Thursday and discussed the issues related to the US-Iran peace talks, amid reports about the possible visit of Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir to Tehran. Naqvi arrived in Tehran on Wednesday on his second trip in less than a week to bridge the gap between the US and Iran, as Pakistan intensified efforts to arrange a deal between the two warring sides and end the war in the region.

Foreign Minister Araghchi met Naqvi in Tehran on Thursday morning to discuss the indirect Iran-US negotiations, Iran's official news agency IRNA reported.

According to state-run Press TV, Munir is "set to visit Tehran on Thursday as Islamabad ramps up Iran-US mediation efforts." There were no immediate comments from Pakistan about the ongoing visit of Naqvi or the possible

“NAQVI ARRIVED IN TEHRAN ON WEDNESDAY ON HIS SECOND TRIP IN LESS THAN A WEEK TO BRIDGE THE US-IRAN GAP”

trip of the army chief. During his second visit to the Iranian capital within a week, Naqvi also held talks with President Masoud Pezeshkian, Iran's interior minister, and other senior officials.

President Pezeshkian and Naqvi discussed the latest regional developments, bilateral relations, and the status of diplomatic consultations linked to the ongoing indirect talks between Iran and the US, IRNA reported. The two sides stressed the necessity of continuing political consultations and strengthening regional cooperation. AGENCIES

Russia holds nuclear drills on land, sea & air, joined by Belarus

MOSCOW: Trucks carrying intercontinental ballistic missiles rumbled over forest roads, atomic-powered submarines set sail from Arctic and Pacific ports, and crews scrambled into warplanes as Russia and neighbouring Belarus held the final stage of their joint nuclear drills Thursday.

Belarus President Alexander Lukashenko inspected Russian short-range nuclear-capable Iskander ballistic missiles at a military unit involved in the drills, declaring: "I dreamed about this machine a long time ago."

The three-day drills that began Tuesday come amid a surge in Ukrainian drone strikes, including on Moscow's suburbs that killed three people and damaged several buildings and industrial facilities.

The strikes made it harder for officials in the Kremlin to cast the conflict

Key Points

- » The three-day drills that began Tuesday come amid a surge in Ukrainian drone strikes
- » Russia's Defence Ministry said the exercise involved 64,000 troops

in Ukraine — now in its fifth year — as something so distant that it doesn't affect the daily routines of Russian civilians.

Russia's Defence Ministry said the exercise involved 64,000 troops, over 200 missile launchers, more than 140 aircraft, 73 surface warships and 13 submarines, including eight armed with nuclear-tipped ICBMs.

The drills will focus on the "preparation and use of nuclear forces under the threat of aggression," it said. AGENCIES

Nepal PM's continued absence from Parl draws strong protests from opposition

KATHMANDU: Lawmakers from multiple opposition parties on Thursday raised slogans to protest the continued absence of Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah 'Balen' in Parliament to respond to their questions, leading to an adjournment as proceedings were disrupted.

This is the third time since the session started last week that the opposition parties have obstructed the proceedings in the House of Representatives



and boycotted the Parliament meetings to oppose Shah's absence.

"Down with the autocratic ruler," "Prime Minister is

responsible to (answer) Parliament," "Address the demands of the Opposition," "Make the Prime Minister accountable to Parliament," and "Implement Parliament's regulation" were the various slogans shouted in the House by members of almost all the opposition parties, including Nepali Congress, CPN-UML -- the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist), Shram Sanskriti Party and Rastriya Prajatantra

Party. "Is the prime minister an emperor of a separate state?" asked Arjun Narasingha KC, a senior leader and Parliament member from the Nepali Congress during the Special Hour in the House.

KC expressed dissatisfaction over the prime minister's absence from the House at a time when the government should be taking serious issues such as disaster management. AGENCIES

Indian students, workers lead exit trend as UK net migration falls

LONDON: Indian students and workers top the charts of foreigners leaving the UK as net migration data released in London on Thursday reflected a significant fall, nearly halved when compared to the previous year.

According to the Office for National Statistics (ONS) analysis for 2025, around 51,000 Indians who came for study reasons, 21,000 for work reasons

and 3,000 for other unspecified reasons led the exit trend followed by Chinese students and workers (46,000).

Ukrainians (18,000), Pakistanis and Nigerians (both 19,000 each) completed the top five emigrating nationalities, resulting in an overall net migration fall to 1,71,000 last year. "Net migration is now at 1,71,000, down from a high of 9,44,000 under the Conser-

vatives. This government is restoring order and control to our borders," said UK Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood.

"We will always welcome those who contribute to this country and wish to build a better life here. But we must restore order and control to our borders. As these statistics show, real progress has been made, but there is still work to do. AGENCIES

Pakistan PM Shehbaz describes China as a 'trusted friend'

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday described China as a "trusted friend" and said that Beijing has supported Islamabad in an "unwavering fashion unmatched in the annals of history."

He made the comments at a special ceremony held in Islamabad to mark the 75th anniversary of Pakistan-China diplomatic relations.

Shehbaz will visit China from May 23 to 26

The prime minister said that Pakistan and China have always supported each other on key issues. "Beijing has supported us in unwavering fashion unmatched in the annals of history," he said.

Shehbaz, who will visit China from May 23 to 26 to hold talks with President Xi Jinping and Premier Li Qiang, reaffirmed that Pakistan has always supported the One-China policy, without fear or favour.

He said Pakistan was the "first Muslim country to recognise China and one of the first countries in the world to do so." AGENCIES

Singapore reports nearly 60% surge in weekly new COVID-19 cases

SINGAPORE: Around 12,700 new COVID-19 cases were recorded in Singapore between May 10 and 16, compared to 8,000 in the previous week - a surge of 58.8 per cent, according to data shared on Thursday by the Communicable Diseases Agency (CDA).

The average number of daily COVID-19 hospitalisations increased from 56 to 73 during the same period, with one case referred to the Intensive Care Unit every day on an average, said the CDA. However, there were no deaths reported in this period, according to the CDA press release. "As with other endemic respiratory diseases, periodic COVID-19 waves are expected throughout the year," the agency said.

"There is no indication that the variants circulating locally are more transmissible or cause more severe disease compared with previously circulating variants." The NB.1.8.1 variant is the main COVID-19 variant circulating in Singapore, accounting for more than half of locally sequenced cases, said the agency. AGENCIES

Republicans expected to abandon \$1 billion security proposal for WH, Trump's ballroom

Republicans could set parameters on Trump's settlement fund

WASHINGTON: Senate Republican leaders are expected to abandon a proposal for \$1 billion in security money for the White House complex and President Donald Trump's ballroom on Thursday amid backlash from members of their own party.

Pressured by the White House, Republicans tried to add the money to a roughly \$70 billion bill to restore funding to US Immigration and Customs Enforcement and the Border Patrol.

But the security proposal met with opposition from some GOP lawmakers who are questioning the timing of the request, the high cost and how the taxpayer dollars would be used. Senate Majority Leader John Thune, R-S.D., acknowledged "ongoing vote issues" on Wednesday as leaders tried to measure Republican support and figure out what will be allowed in the bill under the chamber's rules.

Sen. John Kennedy, R-La., told reporters Wednesday that the bill was "back to square



US President Donald Trump tours Ballroom construction around the outside the White House

AP/PTI

one" without the security money because "the votes are not there."

Thune hopes to pass the bill this week and send it to the House before leaving for a weeklong Memorial Day

recess. But the bill's text has still not been released as leaders were wrangling over the security proposal and new GOP concerns over the Trump administration's \$1.776 billion settlement fund.

Republican senators were set to meet with acting Attorney General Todd Blanche on Thursday morning as they finalised the text and decided whether to put parameters on the settlement, which

was designed to compensate Trump's allies who believe they have been politically persecuted. The last-minute scramble comes as Democrats have criticised Republicans for trying to fund Trump's ballroom when voters are concerned about basic affordability issues — and as some GOP lawmakers have grown increasingly frustrated with Trump.

Several GOP senators have spoken out against the settlement, which was announced this week, and many were upset by the president's endorsement Tuesday of Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton in the party primary runoff next week against Sen. John Cornyn.

"There's always a consequence with taking on United States senators," Thune said Wednesday.

The president "obviously has his favourites and people he wants to endorse and that's his prerogative. But what we have to deal with up here is moving the agenda, and obviously that can become slightly more complicated." AGENCIES

World Briefs

NEW ANTI-HINDU HATE MONITOR PLATFORM LAUNCHED IN UK

LONDON: A new platform to help document incidents of anti-Hindu hate incidents in the UK has been launched as part of efforts to address concerns of rising religiously motivated hate crimes in the country. The Anti-Hindu Hate Monitor (AHHM) is described as a working project under the Future of Faith Desk at the International Centre for Sustainability (ICFS) in London. The think tank said the data collected by the new online platform launched this week will be used to engage with the UK Home Office, law enforcement, local authorities and other relevant stakeholders. "This platform aims to support a collective voice within the Hindu community, helping to ensure that these issues are not faced in isolation," ICFS said.

MYANMAR MILITARY RECAPTURES 2 BORDER TOWNS FROM ETHNIC MILITIAS

BANGKOK: Myanmar's military-backed government says it has regained control of two towns near the country's borders with India and Thailand, marking a significant advance in the civil war as it seeks to reassert control of regions long held by resistance forces. A report in the state-run Myanma Alinn newspaper on Thursday said Tonzang, near the border with India, was captured by the army on Wednesday after 10 days of operations to retake it. The paper published photos of soldiers who recaptured the town in front of the township's administrative office and other departments.

STATE SECRETARY RUBIO SAYS

‘India great partner, US ready to expand energy cooperation’



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio speaks to the press before boarding his plane at Homestead Air Reserve Base on Thursday

WASHINGTON: US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Thursday that the US was in talks with India to expand energy cooperation, an issue that would feature in his discussions during a visit to New Delhi.

“Well, we want to sell them as much energy as they’ll buy. And obviously, you’ve seen I think we’re at historic levels of US production, and US export,” Rubio told reporters in Miami as he embarked on the trip to Sweden and India.

Rubio will be in India from May 23-26 and will visit Kolkata, Agra, Jaipur and New Delhi.

“We want to be able to do more. We were already in talks with them to do more. We want them to be a bigger part of their portfolio. We also think there are opportunities with Venezuelan oil,” Rubio said.

He was responding to a question about India being affected by high energy prices due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Rubio described India as a “great partner” and said his visit to New Delhi was important as it would also give him an opportunity to meet with ministers from the Quad nations.

“They are a great ally, a great partner. We do a lot of good work with them. And so it is an important trip. I’m glad we’re able to do it because I think there’ll be a lot for us to talk about,” Rubio said.

Highlights

» Rubio will be in India from May 23-26 and will visit Kolkata, Agra, Jaipur and New Delhi

» Rubio said the acting President of Venezuela Delcy Rodriguez was also scheduled to visit India next week and there will be many opportunities to work with New Delhi

RUBIO DESCRIBED INDIA AS A “GREAT PARTNER” AND SAID HIS VISIT TO NEW DELHI WAS IMPORTANT

“We’ll also meet with Quad there, which is important. I think my first meeting as Secretary of State was with the Quad. I’m glad we are able to do it now in India and we’re going to do one later in the year as well,” Rubio said.

Rubio said the acting President of Venezuela Delcy Rodriguez was also scheduled to visit India next week and there will be many opportunities to work with New Delhi.

“In fact, it’s my understanding that the interim president of Venezuela will be travelling to India next week as well. So, there’s opportunities. There’s a lot to work on with India,” Rubio said.

‘Looks like ‘I’ll be the one’ to intervene in Cuba after Castro indictment’

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump on Thursday suggested that US presidents have mulled intervening in Cuba for decades but it looks like ‘I’ll be the one that does it’.

“Other presidents have looked at this for 50, 60 years, doing something,” Trump told reporters during an unrelated environmental event in the Oval Office, when asked about

Cuba. “And, it looks like I’ll be the one that does it. So, I would be happy to do it.”

He added that the US wants to open Cuba “up to Cuban Americans, where they can go back and help.”

Trump didn’t answer questions about the aircraft carrier Nimitz having reportedly entered the southern Caribbean on Wednesday. Nor did he



US President Donald Trump

clarify exactly what he meant. Still, the president’s comments

deviated from Wednesday, when the president was asked about a possible US escalation in Cuba and suggested one wasn’t coming.

He called Cuba a failed country and said, “They don’t have electricity. They don’t have money. They don’t have really anything,” before adding, “We’re going to help them along.”

Trump, facing a Senate Republican mutiny, also said on Thursday that he doesn’t “need money for the ballroom”.

Asked about Senate Republicans dropping a proposed \$1 billion for White House security and his ballroom project, Trump said, “I’m making a gift of the ballroom.” Trump says the ballroom will be paid for by himself and donors –

though much about its financing remains mysterious.

Trump drew distinctions between the ballroom and proposed White House security improvements. He said the ballroom was being built “in conjunction” with the military and the Secret Service and that “a tremendous amount” of the project “is for national security.”

AGENCIES

मध्यप्रदेश राज्य पर्यटन विकास निगम मर्यादित

पर्यटन भवन, भदभद्रा रोड, भोपाल- 462003

फोन : +91 755 4027100, 2774340/42, www.mpstdc.com

क्रमांक 231/यात्रिका/पविनि/26 दिनांक : 21.05.2026

निविदा सूचना

मध्यप्रदेश राज्य पर्यटन विकास निगम भोपाल द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑनलाइन (Online) निविदा प्रपत्र APPENDIX 2.10 पर म.प्र. लोक निर्माण विभाग में उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र.	नि.सू. क्र./सिस्टम आई.डी./कार्य का नाम	ठेके की अनुमानित राशि रु. लाख में
1	189/2026_STDC_509666_1/जिला राजगढ़ स्थित Govt. HSS घोघटपुर जीरापुर ब्लॉक (UDISE code 23300606809) में 06 अतिरिक्त क्लास रूम, बाउंड्री, गेट, टॉयलेट ब्लॉक का निर्माण एवं रिनोवेशन का कार्य आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण सहित। कार्यपूर्णता का समय 15 माह	205.63
2	190/2026_STDC_509668_1/जिला राजगढ़ स्थित Govt. HS भगौरा जीरापुर ब्लॉक (UDISE code 23300602806) में 01 अतिरिक्त क्लास रूम, 01 लाइब्रेरी, बाउंड्री, गेट, टॉयलेट ब्लॉक का निर्माण एवं रिनोवेशन का कार्य आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण सहित। कार्यपूर्णता का समय 10 माह	119.42
3	191/2026_STDC_509669_1/जिला राजगढ़ स्थित Govt. HS लखौनी जीरापुर ब्लॉक (UDISE code 23300613008) में 01 अतिरिक्त क्लास रूम, 01 लैब, बाउंड्री, गेट, टॉयलेट ब्लॉक का निर्माण एवं रिनोवेशन का कार्य आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण सहित। कार्यपूर्णता का समय 10 माह	117.99
4	192/2026_STDC_509671_1/जिला राजगढ़ स्थित Govt. HS भंडावाद जीरापुर ब्लॉक (UDISE code 23300603006) में 01 अतिरिक्त क्लास रूम, 02 लैब, बाउंड्री, गेट, टॉयलेट ब्लॉक का निर्माण एवं रिनोवेशन का कार्य आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण सहित। कार्यपूर्णता का समय 10 माह	110.26
5	193/2026_STDC_509672_1/जिला राजगढ़ स्थित Govt. HS S रामगढ़ जीरापुर ब्लॉक (UDISE code 23300617911) में 02 अतिरिक्त क्लास रूम, 01 लैब, बाउंड्री, टॉयलेट ब्लॉक का निर्माण एवं रिनोवेशन का कार्य आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण सहित। कार्यपूर्णता का समय 08 माह	95.03

वेबसाइट पर ऑनलाइन भुगतान कर निविदा प्रपत्र (टेण्डर डाक्यूमेंट) वेबसाइट के माध्यम से क्रय किये जा सकते हैं। निविदा प्रपत्र ऑनलाइन क्रय करने की अंतिम तिथि 12.06.2026 समय सायं 05:00 बजे तक निर्धारित है। कार्य का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

म.प्र. माध्यम/125909/2026 कार्यपालन चंकी

OFFICE OF SECRETARY GENERAL WORLD YOGASANA

Registration No. S/ND/1032/2019 (A Registered Society Under The Societies Registration Act, XXI of 1860)

Registered Address: 58, Ashoka Road, New Delhi-110001, India

Administrative Office: In Campus Guru Gorakhnath Mandir, Sector 7, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075, India

TENDER NOTICE

Expedited Tender- 3 Days Response World Yogasana invites bids from experienced vendors, manufacturers/suppliers for the supply, installation, and commissioning of a Field of Play (FOP) Mat System for 1st World Yogasana Championship in Ahmedabad from 4th June 2026. Deadline: 23 May 2026, 5:00 PM

Details and Submission Guidelines Are available at www.worldyogasana.org (tender section)

Email: secretariat@worldyogasana.org

Jyoti Sharma Office Secretary World Yogasana

FORM NO. INC-26

Advertisement to be Published in the Newspaper [Pursuant to rule 30 the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014]

NOTICE

BEFORE REGIONAL DIRECTOR, NORTHERN REGION, NEW DELHI

In the matter of the Companies Act, 2013, Section 13(4) of Companies Act, 2013 and Rule 30(6) (a) of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014 AND

IN THE MATTER OF M/s MAKAMS INDUSTRIESPRIVATE LIMITED A COMPANY HAVING ITS REGISTERED OFFICE AT F – 12, ADARSHINI PLAZA, 91, ADICHINI, SRI AURBINDO MARG, NEW DELHI – 110017

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Extra ordinary general meeting held on 15th Day of May,2026 to enable the company to change its Registered office from “State of Delhi” to “State of Haryana”.

Any person, whose interest likely to be affected by the said Shifting of Registered Office of the Company from the “State of Delhi” to “State of Haryana” may intimate “THE REGIONAL DIRECTOR, NORTHERN REGION, New Delhi, B-2, WING, 02ND FLOOR, PARYAVARAN BHAVAN,CGO COMPLEX, NEW DELHI-110003” within 21 days from the date of Publication of this notice, the nature of interest and grounds of opposition to the opposition if any, supported by an affidavit and should send the same in original to the Regional Director with a copy to the petitioner at the Registered Office of the Company as mentioned above.

By Order of the Board For MAKAMS INDUSTRIESPRIVATE LIMITED sd/- MUKESH AGARWAL (DIRECTOR) DIN-00251287

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-NOTICE INVITING TENDER

TENDER NOTICE No: 230-Elect-RSO-T01-2026-27, Dt. 19.05.2026

For and on behalf of President of India, Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (RSO), Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites 'E'- Tender in prescribed tender form for the following work.

- Name of the work with its location: Provision of clean, dry silica sand as per specification AAR-M-916-51 and filling of the sand in the sand boxes of Diesel/ Electric locomotives at NDLS, DLI, ANVT & TKD outfits for a period of 24 months.
- Approx. Tender value (Rs) Rs. 78,09,801.60 (including GST).
- E.M.D (Rs) Rs. 1,56,200.00/- Note:-Online payment mode available on IREPS website.
- Date & Time of tender opening (immediately when tender submission ends): 10.06.2026 at 11.00 Hrs.
- Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen:- www.ireps.gov.in 1712/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF PERSONS ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that two accused person namely (1) **Sumit @ Shambhu S/o Ashok Kumar R/o I-790, Mangolpuri, Delhi** (2) **Rakesh @ Bachan S/o Kripal Singh R/o J-1255, Mangolpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 521/17 U/s 392/411/34 IPC at PS: Vikas Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused (1) **Sumit @ Shambhu** (2) **Rakesh @ Bachan** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused (1) **Sumit @ Shambhu** (2) **Rakesh @ Bachan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused (1) **Sumit @ Shambhu** (2) **Rakesh @ Bachan** of **FIR No. 521/17 U/s 392/411/34 IPC of PS: Vikas Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.07.2026**.

By order
Vinod Kumar
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-05
South-West District, Court No.09
Dwarka Courts New Delhi

DP/6501/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) (1) **Mohd. Parvesh S/o: Israil, R/o: Jhuggi No. 272 Rakhi Market Zakhira Delhi Gulabi Bagh, North Delhi** (2) **Sagar Mishra S/o: Late Ram Kumar Mishra, R/o: Jhuggi No. 16/30 Rakhi Market Zakhira Delhi Gulabi Bagh, North Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 340/2022, U/s: 380/411/201/34 IPC, PS: Paschim Vihar Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) (1) **Mohd. Parvesh** (2) **Sagar Mishra**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) (1) **Mohd. Parvesh** (2) **Sagar Mishra**, has absconded (or is concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) (1) **Mohd. Parvesh** (2) **Sagar Mishra**, of **FIR No. 340/2022, U/s: 380/411/201/34 IPC, PS: Paschim Vihar Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.06.2026**.

By Order
Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11 (West)
Room No. 31
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/6526/OD/2026 (Court Matter)

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform public in general that Kotak Mahindra bank Ltd has organized an auction in below mention respect of Vehicles. VEHICLES FOR SALE

- TATA MOTORS TATAACE REG. NO. DL1LAJ0531-YOM- 2022
- TATA MOTORS TSIGNA5530 REG. NO. HR38AE9815-YOM- 2022
- TATA MOTORS LPT1109T REG. NO. DL1MB3459-YOM- NA
- TATA MOTORS TACEGOLCNG REG. NO. DL1LAL6080-YOM- 2023
- TATA MOTORS TATAMOTORS REG. NO. DL1LAL3940-YOM- 2023
- TATA MOTORS TATAACE REG. NO. DL1LAJ9556- YOM- 2023
- TATA MOTORS TATA_INTRA REG. NO. DL1LAN2684-YOM- 2024
- BHARATBENZ BB5428T REG. NO. UP11CT2893-YOM- 2022
- TATA MOTORS TACEGOLD REG. NO. DL1LAH9652-YOM- 2022
- TATA MOTORS TATA_INTRA REG. NO. DL1LAM9813-YOM- 2024
- TATA MOTORS T_INTRA V20 REG. NO. DL1LAQ2728-YOM- NA
- TATA MOTORS TATAACE REG. NO. DL1LAJ2400-YOM- 2021
- TATA MOTORS TATALPT710 REG. NO. DL1LAJ6336-YOM- 2023
- ASHOK LEY AL2820FB REG. NO. UP16KT5666-YOM- 2023

UNDER HYPOTHECATION WITH MS KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK IS UNDER SALE IN ITS “AS IS WHERE IS CONDITION” INTERESTED PARTIES CAN GIVE THEIR QUOTATIONS WITH IN 7 DAYS AT BRANCH ADDRESS: KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK 3RD FLOOR, PLOT NO 7, SECTOR 125,NOIDA-201313 OR CONTACT : RAMAN AHUJA KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK LTD. CONTACT NO. 8377988238 EMAIL-raman.ahuja@kotak.com

OFFICE OF THE DY. COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, SOUTH DISTRICT, NEW DELHI

Hauz Khas, New Delhi- 110016, Telephone No. 011-20863617

Office Ph No.: 011-27454825, Email : adcp1south@gmail.com

PROCLAMATION U/S 67 D.P. ACT - 1978

Now, in exercise of the powers conferred upon me by the Commissioner of Police, Delhi and as envisaged vide section 67(i) of Delhi Police Act, 1978 the enclosed list of 26 vehicles/articles are notified for the information of the general public through this proclamation. Any person, who may have a claim thereof may appear before the concerned SHO of South District along with the proof of the ownership to establish his claim within six months of the issue of this proclamation.

PROCLAMATION U/S 67 D.P. ACT - 1978 of unclaimed vehicles seized U/S 66 D.P ACT By Police Stations of South District: upto 31.03.2025

S No.	Police Station	DD No	Date	Registration No.	Engine No.	Chasis No.	Make	Date of Registration (Life/age)
1	Mehrauli	61A	11/03/2024	DL 1SU 9210	JA06EFCGA10655	MBLJA06EUCGA10088	Motor Cycle	02-02-2012
2	Mehrauli	40A	24/03/2024	DL 11SV 2451	NF5AJ1524237	MD625PF5QJ3A15650	Motor Cycle	05-03-2018
3	Mehrauli	186A	06/08/2024	DL 3SEF 4213	HA10AGKHAA6088	MBLHAR08SKHA66982	Motor Cycle	08-03-2019
4	Mehrauli	143A	08/08/2024	DL 10ST 7063	E3Y4E0057194	ME1SED196H0036461	Scooty	13-08-2017
5	Mehrauli	123A	19/08/2024	DL 3SBN 2806	HA10EA99B14525	MBLHA10EJ99B07415	Motor Cycle	15-02-2009
6	Mehrauli	25A	09/10/2024	DL 4SNC 9271	JC44E0915128	ME4JC449JA8038317	Scooty	17-10-2010
7	Mehrauli	143A	29/10/2024	DL 3SCE 1444	JZUBUM41486	MD2DSJZZUPM11422	Motor Cycle	10-05-2012
8	Mehrauli	133A	15/11/2024	DL 7SAU 8581	DJGBNL06661	MD2DHDJZZNCL79787	Motor Cycle	18-06-2007
9	Mehrauli	34A	19/12/2024	DL 5SAM 7126	BG4FF2035097	MD626BG44F3F22581	Scooty	01-07-2015
10	Mehrauli	50A	18/04/2025	DL 13ST 2997	EG4CH2104987	MD626EG47H3D43133	Scooty	24-04-2017
11	Mehrauli	25A	02/07/2025	UP 14AY 8395	HA 10EA9HL66758	MBLHA10EJ9HL16670	Motor Cycle	01-12-2009
12	Mehrauli	145A	19/07/2025	DL 3SEC 7723	JA06EUJHJ19223	MBLJAR135JHJ05523	Motor Cycle	18-11-2018
13	Mehrauli	160A	23/07/2025	DL 3SDD 0863	JF32AAFGC32207	MBLJF32AEFGC12173	Scooty	30-03-2015
14	Mehrauli	132A	28/07/2025	UP 78CA 3791	A9C06179	MBLHA11ENA9C06278	Motor Cycle	13-05-2010
15	Mehrauli	259A	10/04/2025	DL 3SCR 2599	HA11EFE9C13539	MBLHA11AEE9C30319	Scooty	20-03-2014
16	Mehrauli	10A	09/03/2025	DL 3SEU 6604	HA11EDMHA14385	MBLHAW127MHA32991	Motor Cycle	26-03-2021
17	Mehrauli	175A	25/09/2025	DL 3SED 0993	EG4LJ17H9610	MD626EG49J3L48188	Scooty	26-11-2018
18	Mehrauli	81A	29/11/2025	DL 4SBQ 1290	JC44E0191726	ME4JC445G98191656	Scooty	31-07-2009
19	KM PUR	65A	22/06/2025	UK 06AR 6921	87900	87862	Scooty	02-Jun-18
20	KM PUR	11A	09/06/2025	DL 7SCB 2883	15627	68946	M/CYCLE	25-Dec-16
21	KM PUR	15A	10/06/2025	UP 22Q 7237	33838	F03945	M/CYCLE	10-Jul-12
22	SGV	82A	04/11/2025	DL3SAG0680	DHGBKE46818	DHVBKE46873	SCOOTY	01-Sep-03
23	SGV	102A	09/12/2025	DL3SFE6128	HA11EDNH06106	MBLHAW12XNH27029	SPLENDER	21-Oct-22
24	SGV	140	24/04/2025	DL3SCX0164	DZZPEC46540	MD2A18AZ0EPC45910.	PLETINA	13-Jun-14
25	SGV	121	23/02/2026	DL3SCF1022	U3SSCOBM103788	ME3U3S5COBM103788	BULLET	25.02.2012
26	SGV	93	15/01/2026	DL3SF1183	63393	73093DUP1	SPLENDER	01-Dec-93

DP/9886/SD/2026

Addl. Dy. Commissioner of Police-I South District: Delhi

GAIL reports standalone PAT of ₹6,968 cr for fiscal 2025-26

On a consolidated basis, GAIL's Profit after tax, excluding minority interest, came in at Rs 7,582 crore for full 2025-26 financial year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-run GAIL (India) Limited on Thursday announced its financial results for FY26, highlighting expansion in pipeline infrastructure, record LPG transmission and continued investments in renewable energy and clean fuel projects.

Standalone performance
On a standalone basis, GAIL reported revenue from operations of Rs 1,38,697 crore for FY26, compared with Rs 1,37,288 crore in FY25. EBITDA stood at Rs 13,119 crore, while profit before tax (PBT) was Rs 8,964 crore and profit after tax (PAT) stood at Rs 6,968 crore.

On a sequential basis, for Q4 FY26, revenue from operations stood at Rs 34,797 crore against Rs 34,076 crore in Q3 FY26.

EBITDA during the quarter was Rs 2,175 crore, while profit before tax and profit after tax came in at Rs 1,577 crore and Rs 1,262 crore, respectively.

Operationally, natural gas transmission during FY26 stood at 122.18 MMSCMD, while gas marketing volume was 104.21 MMSCMD. LPG



Deepak Gupta, Chairman & Managing Director, GAIL (India) Limited

On standalone basis, GAIL reported revenue from operations of Rs 1,38,697 crore for FY26, compared with Rs 1,37,288 crore in FY25

transmission reached a record 4,600 TMT during the year.

Consolidated performance

On a consolidated basis, Revenue from Operations in FY26 stood at Rs 1,42,094

Highlights

» On a consolidated basis, Revenue from Operations in FY26 stood at Rs 1,42,094 crore, as against Rs 1,42,290 crore in FY25

» On a sequential basis, for Q4 FY26, revenue from operations stood at Rs 34,797 crore against Rs 34,076 crore in Q3 FY26

» For Q4 FY26, consolidated revenue from operations stood at Rs 35,705 cr against Rs 35,303 cr in Q3 FY26

» The Board of Directors recommended a final dividend of Rs 0.50/ equity share of face value Rs 10 for FY26

at Rs 7,582 crore.

On a sequential basis, for the fourth quarter, consolidated revenue from operations stood at Rs 35,705 crore compared with Rs 35,303 crore in Q3 FY26.

EBITDA was Rs 2,703 crore, while profit before tax stood at Rs 1,966 crore. Profit after tax, excluding minority interest, was Rs 1,485 crore.

The Board of Directors recommended a final dividend of Rs 0.50 per equity share of face value Rs 10 for FY26, subject to shareholder approval at the forthcoming AGM.

This is in addition to the interim dividend of Rs 5 per share already declared, taking the total dividend payout ratio for the year to 51.90 per cent.

The company incurred capital expenditure of Rs 9,594 crore during FY26 towards pipeline infrastructure, petrochemical projects, operational capex and investments in joint ventures and subsidiaries.

Chairman and Managing Director Deepak Gupta said the year was marked by a challenging global backdrop due to the Russia-Ukraine con-

flict and geopolitical developments in West Asia. He said that despite these headwinds, GAIL delivered resilient operational and financial performance with support from timely government policy interventions.

Gupta said the company remained focused on operational continuity, cost discipline and supply reliability to navigate volatile market conditions.

During the year, GAIL added around 2,000 km of pipeline network and achieved its highest-ever LPG transmission of 4.6 MMTPA. He added that the company is doubling the capacity of the Jamnagar-Loni LPG pipeline to 6.5 MMTPA.

Highlighting GAIL's Strategy 2030 and net-zero commitments, Gupta said the Board has approved in-vestments in renewable energy projects, including around 700 MW of solar capacity, about 178 MW of wind capacity and six compressed biogas plants with a combined capacity of nearly 95 TPD, reinforcing the company's focus on energy transition, sustainability and long-term value creation.

US firms commit over \$60 billion investment in last 6 mnths: Goyal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said investment commitments from American companies in the last six months are estimated to exceed \$60 billion, including major data centre investments by firms such as Amazon and Google.

He said India provides a trusted framework for global companies and combines scale, talent and market opportunity in a manner unmatched globally.

Commitments from American industry in the last six months are estimated to be upwards of \$60 billion, including major data centre investments by companies such as Amazon and Google, he said here at the Annual Leadership Summit of the American Chamber of Commerce.

The minister said that America is looking for a trusted partner and India has consistently demonstrated respect for intellectual property rights while delivering high-quality output on time.

India offers a large pool of skilled talent and provides scale to American innovation through demand aggregation from 1.4 billion aspirational Indians, rising incomes and a growing middle class, Goyal said. Later, briefing the media, he said, "The US has announced investments worth around Rs 6 lakh crore in India in the last few months, in data centres, new factories, semiconductor



India provides a trusted framework for global companies and combines scale, talent and market opportunity in a manner unmatched globally, he said

plants and various other things".

Both countries, he said, are working together on new technologies such as AI, quantum computing and machine learning.

"We have finalised an interim phase one of a bilateral trade agreement (BTA), under which India will get preferential access compared to our competitors to the nearly 30 trillion dollar US market," he added.

He also said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is often called by US President Donald Trump as his "very" close friend. "Therefore, I think the

visit of US Secretary of State Marco Rubio is extremely timely and reflects the growing partnership between the US and India, which will provide newer and bigger opportunities to our youth, farmers, women, entrepreneurs, startups, businesses and industries," he said.

Rubio will undertake a four-day visit to India beginning May 23 to further cooperation in the fields of trade, defence and energy. This will be his first visit to India.

In October last year, Google announced that it will invest \$15 billion over the next five years in setting up an AI hub in India, which would include the country's largest data centre in partnership with Adani Group.

Similarly, last month, Amazon India said it plans to invest over Rs 2,800 crore to strengthen associate safety, health and financial well-being measures, and to boost its operations network across the country. The latest investment is part of the company's stated commitment to infuse more than \$35 billion in India by 2030.

₹ rebounds 50 paise to settle at 96.36 against US dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee rebounded 50 paise from its all-time closing low to settle at 96.36 against the US dollar on Thursday after crude oil prices retreated from elevated levels amid signs of easing geopolitical friction, alongside likely central bank intervention.

Forex traders said the rupee had gained after the recent geopolitical developments, but investors are still gauging the geopolitical risk and oil price sensitivity in the background.

The one-year forward market rate for the rupee touched the crucial 100/USD mark on Wednesday, indicating that currency markets are pricing in a weakening bias for the USD/INR pair over the next 12 months, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.25 against the dollar, then touched an early high of 96.05 and a low of 96.60 in intraday trade. At the end of Thursday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 96.36, up 50 paise from its previous closing.

On Wednesday, the rupee hit a record low of 96.95 and later closed at 96.86, which was also a new closing low.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.30, up 0.22 per cent.

RBI to conduct ₹1 lakh crore 3-day VRR auction on May 22

The auction will take place between 9:30 AM and 10 AM, and the reversal of these funds will take place on May 25

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Thursday said that it will conduct a three-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction for a notified amount of Rs 1 lakh crore on May 22.

The auction will take place between 9:30 AM and 10 AM, and the reversal of these funds will take place on May 25, RBI said in a release.

"On a review of current and evolving liquidity conditions, it has been decided to conduct a Variable Rate Repo (VRR) auction on Friday, May 22, 2026," RBI said.

Liquidity surplus in the banking system has narrowed in the last few days, especially after the goods and services



tax outflows. This has led to an uptick in the overnight money market rates.

Currently, the liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around Rs 1.29 lakh crore as on May 20, which is sharply lower than Rs 2.58 lakh crore as on April 30, according to the Reserve Bank

data.

In order to provide liquidity to the banking system and arrest rising overnight money market instrument rates, the central bank has conducted five VRR auctions in the month of May so far, and one on April 30.

However, it received a muted response from the participants despite the narrowing of surplus systemic liquidity.

The overnight VRR auction which happened earlier on Thursday received bids worth Rs 25,360 crore, for a notified amount of Rs 1.25 lakh crore. The central bank accepted the entire amount at a cut-off rate of 5.26 per cent.

IRCTC unveils upgraded Golden Chariot for 2026-27 tourist season with exclusive offers

NEW DELHI: Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC), the tourism arm of Indian Railways, has unveiled the upgraded Golden Chariot luxury train for the 2026-27 tourist season, offering refreshed interiors, enhanced amenities and promotional discounts for select departures.

The revamped train blends heritage charm with modern comforts, featuring refurbished cabins with plush linens, upgraded bath amenities, lacquered wood interiors and muted décor. Smart TVs, Wi-Fi streaming, CCTV surveillance and advanced fire safety systems have also been added to improve passenger comfort and



safety.

The Golden Chariot can accommodate up to 80 guests across 40 cabins, including 13 double-bed cabins, 26 twin-bed cabins and one specially designed cabin for differently abled travellers.

The train houses two fine-dining restaurants — Ruchi and Nalapaka — serving Indian and

international cuisine, along with Madira lounge bar and the Arogya Spa & Fitness Centre offering Ayurvedic therapies and wellness facilities.

IRCTC will operate three itineraries during the season. The six-day "Pride of Karnataka" route covers Bengaluru, Bandipur, Mysuru, Halebidu, Chikkamagaluru, Hampi and Goa. "Jewels of South" includes Mysuru, Kanchipuram, Mahabalipuram, Thanjavur, Chettinad and Kochi, while the shorter "Glimpses of Karnataka" itinerary spans Bengaluru, Bandipur, Mysuru and Hampi over four days.

The company has announced a 20 per cent dis-

count on published tariffs, including supplement charges, for selected departures across all nationalities, subject to cabin availability. Guests completing advance payments by June 30, 2026, will receive an additional 5 per cent early bird discount.

The package includes onboard meals, selected beverages, guided sightseeing in air-conditioned vehicles, monument entry fees and meals at designated outside venues.

Promotional departures include journeys scheduled between October 2026 and March 2027 under the Pride of Karnataka, Jewels of South and Glimpses of Karnataka itineraries.

NEW DELHI: State-run Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL) on Thursday said it has intensified fuel supply and distribution operations across smaller towns, semi-urban centres and remote regions to ensure uninterrupted availability of petrol and diesel amid a recent surge in demand in parts of the country.

The company said metropolitan cities continue to remain adequately supplied, while special focus has been placed on Tier-2, Tier-3 and interior markets where localised demand spikes and precautionary buying have been reported.

BPCL attributed the rise in fuel demand to multiple factors, including higher diesel consumption during the harvesting season, increased preference for PSU fuel outlets in some markets and shifts in purchasing patterns amid prevailing conditions.

Its integrated supply chain network, including refineries, depots, terminals, transport logistics and retail outlets, is operating efficiently with round-the-clock monitoring and coordination between regional and field teams.

Between May 1 and May 20, 2026, BPCL's petrol sales rose 16.38 per cent to 1005 TKL from 864 TKL a year earlier.

and Telecom (0.80 per cent).

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 0.71 per cent to \$104.3 per barrel.

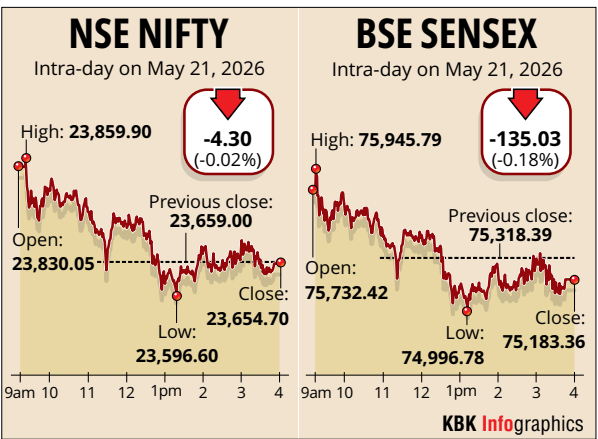
In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi and Japan's Nikkei 225 index ended higher. The Kospi surged over 8 per cent.

Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower.

Markets in Europe were trading in positive territory. US markets ended significantly higher on Wednesday.

FIIs offloaded equities worth Rs 1,597.35 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the 30-share BSE benchmark climbed 117.54 points, or 0.16 per cent, to settle at 75,318.39. The Nifty edged higher by 41 points, or 0.17 per cent, to end at 23,659.



Cap Select index climbed 0.48 per cent, while the MidCap Select index ended almost unchanged.

Among sectoral indices, IT declined the most, by 0.53 per cent, followed by Focused IT (0.52 per cent), Mid-Small Private Banks Quality

Tilt (0.46 per cent), Utilities (0.42 per cent), FMCG (0.42 per cent), and Bankex (0.24 per cent).

However, Services jumped 1.59 per cent, followed by Capital Goods (1.29 per cent), Industrials (1.08 per cent), Commodities (0.91 per cent)

Bharat Petroleum ramps up fuel supplies amid surge in demand

Diesel sales increased 16.69 per cent to 1677 TKL compared with 1437 TKL in the corresponding period last year.

On May 19, BPCL recorded petrol sales of 52.2 TKL and diesel sales of 93.5 TKL, while on May 20, petrol sales stood at 51.2 TKL and diesel at 92.1 TKL.

The company said additional tanker movements, depot inventory optimisation and continuous replenishment monitoring have been initiated in high-demand regions.

BPCL also urged consumers to avoid panic buying and rely only on official communication channels for updates.

DRI seizes 3 lakh vapes worth ₹120 cr: FinMin

NEW DELHI: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has seized 3 lakh electronic cigarettes/vapes worth Rs 120 crore in its crackdown operation against a smuggling racket across Maharashtra, Gujarat, Delhi and West Bengal, the finance ministry said on Thursday.

These prohibited e-cigarettes were found to be sourced from China in every instance and imported concealed in items like furniture and metal chair parts, the ministry statement said.

Acting on specific intelligence, DRI identified, tracked and intercepted multiple sus-

picious import consignments that were mis-declared to evade customs scrutiny.

Detailed examination led to the seizure of nearly 3 lakh electronic cigarettes/vapes of various brands, flavours and specifications valued at more than Rs 120 crore.

Electronic cigarettes and all Electronic Nicotine Delivery Systems (ENDS) are prohibited in India under the Prohibition of Electronic Cigarettes (Production, Manufacture, Import, Export, Transport, Sale, Distribution, Storage and Advertisement) Act, 2019, enacted in the interest of public health and to protect people from harm.

Giriraj Singh inaugurates National Seminar on 'New Age Fibres'

Seminar was organised by Textiles Ministry via National Jute Board, bringing together a spectrum of stakeholders

NEW DELHI: Union Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh inaugurated a national seminar on "New Age Fibre: Innovation, Research and the Road Ahead" in New Delhi on May 19, 2026, highlighting the role of sustainable fibres in promoting eco-friendly growth and rural employment.

Organised by the Ministry of Textiles through the National Jute Board, the seminar brought together policymakers, industry leaders, researchers, startups and academicians to discuss the future of emerging sustainable fibres in India's textile sector.

Addressing the event, Singh



said new-age fibres could help reduce environmental impact, generate jobs and support the

vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat. He also announced regular virtual meetings with stakehold-

CLOSER LOOK
» The seminar focused on fibres such as pineapple, flax, bamboo, hemp, banana, ramie, nettle, milkweed and kapok
» 'These fibres could support agricultural diversification, rural livelihoods and value-added exports'

ers to accelerate development of the sector.

Minister of State for Textiles

Pabitra Margherita stressed the importance of innovation, skill development and grassroots entrepreneurship, while Textiles Secretary Neelam Shami Rao called for translating discussions into actionable policy measures.

The seminar focused on fibres such as pineapple, flax, bamboo, hemp, banana, ramie, nettle, milkweed and kapok, which are gaining recognition for their biodegradable and eco-friendly properties. Officials said these fibres could support agricultural diversification, rural livelihoods and value-added exports.

The event also featured the inauguration of a "New Age Fibres Expo", showcasing products and technologies based on natural fibres. A booklet on new-age fibres and reports prepared by three task forces were also released to guide future policy development. Four thematic sessions discussed policy frameworks, entrepreneurship, technology challenges and a long-term roadmap for integrating sustainable fibres into India's textile economy by 2030. Recommendations from the seminar are expected to shape a comprehensive policy framework for the sector.

APSEZ and Adani Power seal Jaypee Asset deals of ₹5,694 cr

APSEZ will acquire a 100% stake in Jaypee Fertilizers & Industries from Jaiprakash Associates for ₹1,500 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) on Thursday said it will acquire a 100 per cent stake in Jaypee Fertilizers & Industries Limited (JFIL) from Jaiprakash Associates for Rs 1,500 crore, as part of the NCLT-approved resolution plan for JAL.

APSEZ, in a regulatory filing, said the acquisition will further consolidate the company's inland logistics presence and service capabilities in North India.

The acquisition aligns with the company's ambition to expand its MMLP (Multi-Modal Logistics Park) network from 12 to 16 and warehousing capacity by 4X by 2031, it added. "As part of the implementation of the approved resolution plan, the company has entered into a share purchase agreement with Jaiprakash Associates Limited for the acquisition of 100 per cent of the shareholding of Jaypee Fertilizers & Industries Limited (the holding company of KFCL), held by JAL (Jaiprakash Associates Limited)," the country's largest private port operator said.

JFIL is the holding company of Kanpur Fertilizers and



APSEZ said the acquisition will further consolidate company's inland logistics presence & service capabilities in North India

Chemicals Limited (KFCL), which has certain industrial and commercial land parcels in Kanpur.

KFCL holds 243 acres of land in Kanpur, strategically ideal for the development of a world-class logistics park and warehousing facilities aligned with the company's logistics business.

The acquisition is expected to be consummated on the 'effective date' under the approved resolution plan, which will not be later than 90 days from March 17, 2026.

Highlights

- » The acquisition of JFIL will further consolidate company's inland logistics presence and service capabilities in North India, APSEZ said
- » CCI approval has already been obtained on August 26, 2025
- » Adani Power has entered into definitive agreements to acquire 24% stake in JPVL & other thermal assets from Jaypee Associates for Rs 4,193.59 crore

Competition Commission of India approval has already been obtained on August 26, 2025. The resolution plan was approved by the National Company Law Tribunal, Allahabad bench in Prayagraj on March 17, 2026, which was further upheld by the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal on May 04, 2026.

JFIL is engaged in the business directly or by making investments in other companies having similar objectives, including manufacturers, fabricators, processors, producers,

importers, exporters, buyers, and sellers of all kinds of fertilisers and chemicals.

Further, Adani Power said it has entered into definitive agreements to acquire a 24 per cent stake in Jaiprakash Power Ventures Lts (JPVL) and other thermal assets from Jaiprakash Associates for about Rs 4,193.59 crore.

According to a regulatory filing, the company has also inked a Share Purchase Agreement for the acquisition of 24 per cent shares of JPVL, held by Jaiprakash Associates.

Moreover, Adani Power has inked a Business Transfer Agreement for the acquisition of the 180 MW thermal power plant of Jaiprakash Associates located in Churk and other related assets, including 11.49 per cent shares of Prayagraj Power Generation Company Ltd, held by Jaiprakash Associates.

It stated that the consideration for 24 per cent of the shareholding of JPVL, held by JAL, stood at Rs 2,993.60 crore and for the 180 MW thermal power plant of JAL located in Churk and other related assets, including 11.49 per cent shares of Prayagraj Power Generation Company Ltd, held by JAL, is Rs 1,200 crore.

LIC March qtr net profit jumps 23% to quarterly high of ₹23,420 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) on Thursday posted a 23 per cent increase in net profit to Rs 23,420 crore in the March quarter, helped by core business and return on investment.

The country's biggest insurer had earned a profit of Rs 19,013 crore in the corresponding quarter a year earlier.

The total income of the insurer during the reporting quarter rose to Rs 2,53,592 crore from Rs 2,22,805 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year, LIC said in a regulatory filing.

LIC's income from first-year premium also improved to Rs 12,970 crore in the latest January-March quarter against Rs 11,069 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year.

Income from renewal premiums in the reporting period increased to Rs 81,933 crore compared to Rs 79,138 crore a year ago.

During the quarter, total income increased to Rs 1,64,691 crore as against Rs 1,47,586 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal.

Commenting on quarterly numbers, LIC CEO and MD R Doraiswamy said the reduction in GST has helped the business to grow during FY26.

The government brought down the GST on individual health and life insurance premiums from 18 per cent to nil, effective September 22, 2025.

Besides, he said, "Our strat-



The total income of the insurer during Q4 FY26 rose to Rs 2,53,592 crore from Rs 2,22,805 crore in Q4 FY25

egy of channel diversification has been successful with our Banca and Alternate Channels (BAC) having recorded a growth rate of more than 45 per cent with premium from BAC exceeding Rs 5,000 crores in FY26."

Value of New Business (VNB) growth has been in excess of 41 per cent, he said.

During the financial year ended March 2026, LIC earned a profit of Rs 57,419 crore, up 19 per cent from Rs 48,151 crore in the previous fiscal year.

Total income during the financial year rose to Rs 9,73,288 crore as against Rs 8,84,148 crore in the previous financial year.

The total premium income improved to Rs 5,35,984 crore as compared to Rs 4,88,148 crore for the year ended March 31 2025, registering a growth of

Key Points

- » LIC's income from first-year premium also improved to Rs 12,970 crore in Q4 FY26 against Rs 11,069 crore in Q4 FY25
- » Income from renewal premiums in Q4 FY26 jumped to Rs 81,933 crore against Rs 79,138 crore a year ago
- » During fiscal 2026, LIC earned a profit of Rs 57,419 cr, up 19% from Rs 48,151 cr in FY25

9.8 per cent.

In terms of market share measured by First Year Premium Income (FYPI) (as per IRDAI), LIC continues to be the market leader by market share in the Indian life insurance business with an overall market share of 56.66 per cent for FY26 as compared to 57.05 per cent for FY25.

For the year ended March 31 2026, LIC had a market share of 36.6 per cent in the individual business and 70.11 per cent in the group business.

A total of 1,84,41,175 policies were sold in the individual segment as compared to 1,77,82,975 policies sold during the year ended March 31, 2025, registering an increase of 3.7 per cent.

The Solvency Ratio increased to 2.35 as against 2.11 as on March 31, 2025.

Also, recently, he said, "We have announced a bonus issue in the ratio of 1:1 to reward our shareholders. With regulatory guidance, we are preparing to implement the Indian Accounting Standards (IndAS) norms and are confident about implementing within the allowed regulatory time frames."

The board of the insurance company recommended a final dividend of Rs 10 per equity share of Rs 10 each (equivalent to Rs 20 per equity share pre-bonus issue basis) for 2025-26, subject to approval of shareholders, it said.

"We are convinced about continuing our growth journey and crossing new milestones in the coming years," he said.

Asked if the Middle East crisis would have an impact on business, Doraiswamy said, "There may be some impact, but still we are expecting double-digit growth in the current financial year."

On the asset monetisation, he said, "We are looking at various options, including how to get higher rental value from our assets across the country."

The Assets Under Management (AUM) increased to Rs 57,29,396 crore as of March 31, 2026, as compared to Rs 54,52,297 crore on March 31, 2025, registering an increase of 5.08 per cent year on year.

The amount of bonus allocated to policyholders is Rs 59,726 crore for the financial year 2025-26 as against Rs 56,190 crore for the previous financial year.

Zepto plans to float ₹11K cr IPO in July

NEW DELHI: Quick commerce platform Zepto plans to launch its Rs 11,000-crore initial public offering (IPO) in July, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday.

If the listing goes through, Zepto will join rivals Zomato and Swiggy, which are already listed on stock exchanges.

The Bengaluru-based startup, which secured approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) earlier this month for its maiden public issue, is now expected to submit its Updated Draft Red Herring Prospectus (UDRHP) to the regulator.

The delivery app filed its IPO papers using the confidential route in December 2025. People familiar with the matter said that Zepto, founded by Stanford University dropouts Aadit Pali-cha and Kaivalya Vohra, is aiming to list on the bourses before July 31.

According to a recent report by brokerage Bernstein, Zepto is pursuing a markedly different growth strategy from its rivals by focusing on market density and operational intensity rather than rapid geographic expansion.

A present, Zepto has the highest dark-store concentration in the quick commerce segment, with nearly 21 stores per city, compared to around nine stores per city for peers, it added.

Zepto operates 1,255 dark stores across 61 cities, compared to rival Blinkit, which has 2,222 stores spread across 243 cities. PTI

Businesses can digitally record delivery of goods on e-way bill portal: GST Network

NEW DELHI: GST registered businesses can now digitally record delivery of goods for which a e-way bill was generated on the portal, GST Network said.

In an advisory to taxpayers, GSTN, which manages the tech backbone of goods and services tax (GST) said, "A new e-way bill closure facility has been introduced in the e-way bill system on voluntary basis to enable closure of the e-way bill once delivery of goods is completed."

Until now, the e-way bill framework primarily tracked initiation and transit of goods movement, but lacked a formal mechanism to digitally record completion of delivery. This closure feature would create a clearer end-to-end transaction trail and strengthens logistical

Under GST, a person carrying goods valued over Rs 50,000 has to carry an e-way bill

accountability.

Under GST, a person carrying goods valued over Rs 50,000 has to carry an e-way bill. The document is required to be generated from the GST Portal by a GST-registered person or transporter before transporting the goods.

The GSTN said e-way bill may be closed by either supplier, or recipient, or transporter involved in the transaction, or driver or any authorised person whose mobile number has been provided for closure. It fur-

ther said the changes are being implemented in the e-way bill system with a view to strengthening data integrity, improving traceability of goods movement, and enabling system-driven closure of transactions. It also asked taxpayers, transporters, ERP/API integrators, and other stakeholders to initiate necessary system readiness measures.

AMRG Global Managing Partner Rajat Mohan said the introduction of the e-way bill closure facility marks an important evolution in GST's digital compliance architecture and businesses with large supply chains should begin evaluating operational readiness early.

"While currently introduced as a voluntary mechanism, there is a strong possibility that GSTN may gradually move towards making such closure a man-

datory compliance step. If that happens, it could materially strengthen invoice-to-delivery reconciliation and help address concerns around circular trading, round-tripping, duplicate invoicing, and fictitious movement of goods," Mohan said.

When the goods and services tax (GST) was introduced on July 1, 2017, physical check posts across states were abolished, marking a major structural reform, significantly improving free movement of goods and reducing transit delays.

The e-way bill system emerged as an effective digital substitute, enabling online tracking of goods movement while supporting tax administration objectives without reintroducing physical barriers at the state borders. PTI

Maruti Suzuki to hike prices across models by up to ₹30K from June

NEW DELHI: Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India on Thursday said it will hike prices of its vehicles prices across models by up to Rs 30,000 from June 2026 citing inflationary pressures and adverse cost environment.

The company has decided to increase prices of its models across its portfolio by up to Rs 30,000 with effect from June 2026, Maruti Suzuki India said in a regulatory filing.

"For the past few months, the company has been making continuous efforts to mitigate the cost impact to the extent possible through cost reduction measures," it added.

However, it further said, "With inflationary pressures now at elevated levels and

the adverse cost environment persisting, the company has to pass on a portion of the increased costs to the market, while continuing to ensure that the impact on customers is kept to the minimum extent possible."

Maruti Suzuki India currently sells a range of vehicles from entry level S-Presso to premium utility vehicle Invicto priced between Rs 3.49 lakh and Rs 28.7 lakh (ex-showroom).

Last year in September after GST 2.0 kicked in, the company had cut prices of entry-level model S-Presso by up to Rs 1,29,600; Alto K10 by up to Rs 1,07,600; Celerio by Rs 94,100 and Wagon-R by up to Rs 79,600, among others. PTI

HPCL dismisses rumours of fuel shortage in Rajasthan

JAIPUR: Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd on Thursday assured customers that fuel supplies across Rajasthan, including Jaipur, remain stable and adequate, urging people not to believe rumours or panic messages circulating on social media.

The company said all retail outlets in the state were operating normally with uninterrupted supply and regular replenishment support.

The statement came amid concerns over alleged fuel shortages at some petrol pumps, with Congress leaders demanding that the government clarify the actual availability of petrol, diesel and LPG in the state.

Reports claimed some pumps were supplying fuel in limited quantities.

HPCL said petrol sales in Rajasthan rose 19 per cent to 50,575 kilolitres (KL) between May 1 and May 20, compared with historical sales of 42,501 KL.

Diesel sales increased 24.5 per cent to 1,14,422 KL during the period against historical sales of 91,894 KL.

The company said its officers and field teams were closely monitoring the situation and coordinating with dealers and customers to discourage panic buying. It added that the figures reflected adequate product availability and smooth supply operations across the state. AGENCIES

Unincorporated establishments surge to over 9 crore, jobs hit 15 crore mark: Govt survey

The unincorporated non-agricultural sector recorded a year-on-year growth of 16.69 per cent in the number of establishments

NEW DELHI: The number of unincorporated establishments in the non-agriculture sector has surged to over 9 crore, and employment under these firms crossed the 15-crore mark in the January-March quarter, according to a government survey.

The National Statistics Office (NSO) under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation on Thursday released Quarterly Estimates of the Unincorporated Non-Agricultural Sector for the quarter January to March 2026.

NSO has been publishing quarterly bulletins on key findings from the unincorporated

non-agricultural sector since 2025.

The Quarterly Bulletin on Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (QBUSE) for January-March 2026 represents the quarterly edition of the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) and provides key estimates at more frequent intervals.

The introduction of QBUSE reflects NSO's continued efforts to deliver timely and actionable data to policymakers, researchers, and other stakeholders on one of the most dynamic segments of the Indian economy, the survey said.

The unincorporated non-agricultural sector recorded a year-on-year growth of 16.69 per cent in the number of establishments, with the estimated number of unincorporated entities rising to 9.16 crore during January-March 2026 compared to 7.85 crore in the corresponding quarter of the preceding year.

The rural sector emerged as the primary driver of this growth, registering a notable increase of 20.46 per cent.

The urban sector witnessed a growth of 12.59 per cent during the same period. Employment in the unincor-

CLOSER LOOK

- » The estimated number of unincorporated entities rose to 9.16 crore during January-March 2026 against 7.85 crore in corresponding quarter of the preceding year
- » The rural sector emerged as the primary driver of this growth, registering a notable increase of 20.46%
- » The urban sector witnessed a growth of 12.59 per cent during the same period

porated non-agricultural sector reached 15.17 crore in the January-March 2026, crossing the 15-crore mark for the first time.

The sector recorded a year-on-year growth of 15.51 per cent over the corresponding quarter

of the previous year, highlighting its growing significance in generating employment opportunities for a large section of the population across sectors.

Working owners continued to account for the largest

share of the workforce in the unincorporated sector for the January-March 2026 quarter, constituting 60.97 per cent of total workers compared to 58.29 per cent in the corresponding quarter of the preceding year.

In contrast, the share of hired workers witnessed a marginal decline, falling to 24.77 per cent from 26.86 per cent over the same period.

The growing importance of unincorporated enterprises in supporting the rural economy was further reflected in the robust growth of the rural workforce, which recorded an increase of 21.65 per cent dur-

ing the period against 10.39 per cent growth in the urban sector.

Many unincorporated units depend on casual labour, migrant workers, and helpers who often shift to seasonal agricultural work and return either as an entrepreneur or as a worker when activity in the sector strengthens, leading to a rise in employment and establishments, according to the survey.

The January-March 2026 quarter witnessed significant growth in the unincorporated services sector, with significant year-on-year expansion in the number of establishments and employment. The number of

establishments increased by 24.82 per cent, while the workforce in the sector grew by 31.13 per cent over the same period.

The strong expansion of the services sector within the unincorporated economy reflects rising entrepreneurial activity in this sector, its growing role as a key driver of employment and increasing demand for local services.

The women workforce remained impressive, constituting about 29 per cent of total employment in the sector.

This is slightly higher than the numbers in the same quarter of ASUSE 2025. PTI

Red and Gold rush

East Bengal end 22-Year drought in dramatic ISL finish

KOLKATA: East Bengal FC were crowned champions of the Indian Super League for the first time here on Thursday, ending a 22-year-old title drought in the country's top-tier competition and quenching their passionate fans' yearning for silverware after a thrilling five-horse race to the top prize.

East Bengal, one of the country's most decorated football clubs alongside its arch-rivals Mohun Bagan Super Giant, emerged triumphant after a hard-fought 2-1 victory over Inter Kashi at the Kishore Bharati Krirangan, even as Mohun Bagan, another contender for the prize alongside Mumbai City FC, Punjab City and Bengaluru FC heading into the decisive final round of fixtures, rallied to beat Sporting Club Delhi 2-1 at Yuba Bharati Krirangan.

Mumbai FC beat Punjab FC 2-0 in their face-off, while Odisha FC and Jamshedpur FC played out a goalless draw in an inconsequential game.

Both East Bengal and Mohun Bagan ended their campaign with 26 points from 13 matches but the former won on super goal difference of +19 compared to their rivals' +13.

Former winners Mumbai City and Bengaluru FC settled



East Bengal fans celebrate by thronging the ground as the team's players lift the trophy

for the third and fourth place respectively after a dramatic final day's play of the truncated league.

East Bengal, though, were made to work hard until the last minute after Alfred's brilliant first-time finish put Inter Kashi in lead on the 15th minute.

After missing multiple chances to equalise before the break, Oscar Bruzon's transformed side found the much-needed equaliser in the 50th minute through striker Youssef Ezzejari, who is also the winner of the Golden Boot after finishing as the league's highest

30 **EB have been by far the best side in the competition, scoring 30 goals. Eleven of them were scored by Ezzejari**

goalscorer with 11 strikes from 13 matches.

Mohammed Rashid scored East Bengal's second goal in the 73rd minute as the Kolkata heavyweights turned the game around in stunning fashion.

East Bengal last won the top-tier domestic league title



PTI

difference of +18 compared to Mohun Bagan's +13.

Three other teams -- Mumbai City FC, Punjab FC and Jamshedpur FC -- were also mathematically alive in the title race heading into the final round fixtures.

Moments after the final whistle confirmed East Bengal as champions, thousands of fans erupted into deafening chants of "Joy East Bengal", waving giant flags, lighting flares and embracing one another in emotional scenes inside and outside the stadium.

AGENCIES

EYES MULTI-FORMAT IMPACT

Nitish unlocks new gear with pace boost



Nitish Kumar Reddy's transformation hasn't gone unnoticed

PTI

BENGALURU: When England speedster Jofra Archer became the template for refining Nitish Kumar Reddy's bowling action, the results were bound to be exhilarating.

Nitish has shown improved accuracy and a notable spike in his pace during the ongoing edition of IPL -- from a trundler bowling at late 120 kmph to someone who can touch late 130 to early 140 clicks, his transformation with the ball has not gone unnoticed.

Chief selector Ajit Agarkar recently highlighted the all-rounder's improved bowling while explaining his inclusion in India's squads for the upcoming one-off Test and ODI series against Afghanistan.

"We have seen a lot of progress over the last few months with regards to his bowling. He will be a critical part of our team if he keeps developing, especially leading to 2027 ODI WC," Agarkar had said.

Nitish's transformation will certainly add a lot more teeth to India's bowling attack and how has he done it?

"It's the understanding that fast bowling is more about the brain than muscle and the brain can be trained quickly by waking it up. Nitish was a bit asleep in his bowling earlier.

“Nitish was a bit asleep in his bowling earlier. All I did was just to wake him up

Steffan Jones, pace bowling coach

All I did was just to wake him up by training methods that he hadn't done before," Steffan Jones, a renowned pace bowling coach from England, said.

So, what were those training methods? "It was a seven-day session and skill requires frequency of practice. So, we made sure that every ball he bowled was flat out. We minimised the fatigue, because when you're tired, you're not working on speed. But it was multiple exposures of moving quickly, of bowling quickly," said Jones.

"That was the training -- lots of bowling with heavy and light balls, I also kept Varun Aaron (SRH bowling coach) in the loop with all of it because I coached Varun as well for three weeks during his playing days."

AGENCIES

Anti-Doping Act set to be amended

NEW DELHI: The recently-amended National Anti Doping Act will be modified once again to criminalise trafficking and distribution of prohibited substances to athletes with a jail term of upto five years for suppliers, targeting even medical practitioners if they knowingly prescribe banned drugs.

The proposed amendments have been uploaded on the Sports Ministry's website for requisite feedback from the public with the deadline for submission being June 18.

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said the amended bill will be tabled during the upcoming monsoon session of the Parliament after taking the feedback into consideration.

"Whoever administers or applies to an athlete, for the purpose of or in connection with doping in sport...shall be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to (five) years, or with fine which may extend up to (two lakh) rupees, or both," the proposed amendment states.

Mandaviya, who has long advocated for aggressive awareness campaigns to tackle the menace, said criminalising organised supply of banned drugs is a necessity.

AGENCIES

RCB seek top-place finish as SRH chase Qualifier 1 berth

HYDERABAD: Defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Sunrisers Hyderabad will both be eyeing a top-two finish when they square off in their final IPL league match here on Friday.

RCB currently sit atop the points table with 18 points and the best net run rate (NRR) of 1.065 among the 10 teams. A victory on Friday would guarantee them a first-place finish and two opportunities to reach the final.

Sunrisers Hyderabad, meanwhile, are placed third with 16 points from 13 matches, level with Gujarat Titans but behind on NRR. SRH have an NRR of 0.350 compared to GT's 0.400 and their best chance of breaking into the top two would be to beat RCB convincingly and hope Chennai Super Kings defeat GT.

RCB have once again enjoyed an outstanding campaign under skipper Rajat Patidar, blending explosive batting with disciplined bowling to emerge as title contenders for the second successive season.

The talismanic Virat Kohli has continued to redefine consistency at the top of the order, collecting 542 runs from 13 matches, while Devdutt Padikkal has also enjoyed a good season. The experienced pace duo of Bhuvneshwar



Virat Kohli during a training session

PTI

RCB have once again enjoyed an outstanding campaign under skipper Rajat Patidar

Kumar and Josh Hazlewood has also played a pivotal role in RCB's success. Bhuvneshwar has been among the leading wicket-takers this season, making the new ball talk regularly, while Hazlewood has delivered impactful spells at crucial moments.

Krunal Pandya too has impressed with his all-round value, troubling batters with subtle variations. Leg-spinner

ALL-ROUND PERFORMANCE BY GT

End of the road for CSK as Titans close in on top two

AHMEDABAD: Gujarat Titans' top-order laid the groundwork for a dominating 89-run win over Chennai Super Kings here on Thursday, taking them closer to a top-two qualification for the Indian Premier League playoffs.

Shubman Gill (64 off 37) and Sai Sudharsan (84 off 53) added to their remarkable consistency as an opening pair with a record seventh century partnership, fuelling Gujarat Titans to 229 for four on a true batting surface.

Jos Buttler (57 not out off 27) blasted a barrage of sixes and fours in the second half of the innings to prop up the total.

CSK, who had a slim chance of making the play-offs going into this must-win game, lost the match in the powerplay when they lost four wickets for 51 runs. The visitors were all out for 140 in 13.4 overs after a six filled cameo from Shivam Dube (47 off 17).

For the third straight season, the five-time champions failed to make the playoffs.

Mohammed Siraj took three wickets in the first six overs, including that of Sanju Samson, who edged the very first delivery of the CSK innings. Samson fished at a wide delivery and got a faint tinkle on way to Buttler.

Titans' bowling unit has



Mohammed Siraj picked up three wickets in the first six overs

PTI

For the third straight season, the five-time champions failed to make the playoffs

arguably been the best in the tournament and they reinforced with a stellar show in the first six overs. Completing Siraj, Kagiso Rabada had Matthew Short at mid on off a ball that seamed back in slightly and the Australia could not connect properly. Titans capped off their successful stage campaign with nine wins in 14 matches, totalling 18 points.

Sunrisers Hyderabad too can reach 18 points if they win against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, who are already on 18

points, tomorrow. The top two sides out of four playoff teams get two shots at reaching the final scheduled in Ahmedabad on May 31.

Earlier, Gill displayed sublime touch from ball one, toying with the left arm pacer Spencer Johnson in the powerplay.

Gill got his fifty off 23 balls while Sudharsan reached the milestone off 35 balls, his fifth consecutive half-century. Gill scored the bulk of the runs in their 125-run stand off 74 balls.

The range of boundaries Gill picked up off a wayward Johnson was a masterclass in batting. He mixed minimum muscle with trademark elegance to get the desired results.

His fours off Johnson included a cut off the Australian's very first ball.

AGENCIES

Super Chess Classic: Praggn held by Bogdan-Daniel; Firouzja out

BUCHAREST: Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa was held to a draw by Romanian Deac Bogdan-Daniel while France's Alireza Firouzja decided to finally call it quits in the sixth round of the Super Chess Classic, part of the Grand Chess Tour.

Alireza, who played two games despite an ankle injury, decided it was not possible for him to continue and withdrew on the rest day of the ten-players nine-rounds tournament. Germany's Vincent Keymer was the one to benefit from Firouzja's withdrawal as he stretched his lead to a full point after getting a walk over in this round.

While all the other games ended in draws, Keymer remained as the sole leader on 4.5 points, a full point clear of Holland's Jorden Van Foreest and Anish Giri, top seeded American Fabiano Caruana and Praggnanandhaa who all have 3.5 point each.

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France and Wesley share the third spot on three points apiece while World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan is close



behind on 2.5 points. Romanian Deac Bogdan-Daniel is in ninth spot with two points and Firouzja ended his campaign on one point from five games.

Deac Bogdan-Daniel might be the lowest ranked but the Romanian has time and again proved why he is the local pick for the main event as a wild card. Praggnanandhaa went for complications right from the opening by going for the Stonewall Dutch but Deac did not flinch and matched the Indian move-for-move. The pieces got traded at regular intervals and even though Praggnanandhaa picked a temporary pawn, the draw was a foregone conclusion. It was over in 68 moves.

AGENCIES

Fed Cup: Athletes to vie for CWG berths, AFI to begin SRY Gene test

RANCHI: A host of the country's top track and field stars will seek to impress national selectors for 2026 Commonwealth Games berth during the four-day Senior Federation Competition beginning here on Friday.

The meet is also significant as it is the first time the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) will conduct SRY Gene Test at the national level in a bid to ensure that only biological females compete in women's category. It's a mandatory once-in-a-lifetime test will be conducted via a cheek swab or blood test.

The AFI will also start DNA testing of the Indian athletes to collect and preserve their data which could be used later for research and development, prevention of injuries, among other reasons. The results and records of both the SRY tests and DNA tests will be kept confidential. Besides being the final selection event for the 2026 CWG in Glasgow (July 23 to August 2), the May 22-24 Federation Competition will also serve as the trials for the inaugural Asian U23 Championships, to be held in China.

The meet will, however, not see in action the likes of star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra



Murali Sreeshankar is among the top athletes competing

FILE

and 3000m steeplechaser Avinash Sable. Chopra has participated in a national event only once in the last five years as he trains and competes in major international events like the Diamond League and World Championships.

Women's 3000m steeplechase national record holder Parul Chaudhary has also not entered her name for the Ranchi meet. She recorded her second career-best time to finish seventh in the season-opening Diamond League meeting in Shanghai on May 16.

Among the top athletes who will compete are javelin thrower Sachin Yadav, long jumper Murali Sreeshankar, sprinter Animesh Kujur, quartermiler Vishal TK, high hurdler Tejas Shirshe, decathlete Tejaswin Shankar.

AGENCIES

Aston Villa and Prince William celebrate Europa League final triumph

ISTANBUL: In front of the future king of England, Unai Emery reaffirmed his status as the king of the Europa League.

Aston Villa beat Freiburg 3-0 in Istanbul on Wednesday to secure Emery a record-extending fifth title in this competition.

Celebrating wildly inside the Tupras Stadium was life-long Villa fan Prince William, who traveled to watch his beloved team end a 30-year wait for a major trophy.

"Amazing night!! Huge congratulations to all the players, team, staff and everyone connected to the club!" the Prince posted on X.

He had his phone out taking photos as captain John McGinn lifted the cup in the center of the field and in front of an explosion of confetti. "He's a classy guy. He was in the dress-



Aston Villa's John McGinn prepares to lift the trophy

AP

ing room before the game and he's a massive Villa fan so he was never going to miss it," McGinn told TNT Sports.

It was Villa's first major

piece of silverware since winning the English League Cup in 1996 and its first continental title since lifting the European Cup and then the Super

5 **Unai Emery has now won the UEFA Europa League for a fifth time**

Cup in 1982.

Was the outcome ever in doubt with the ultimate Europa League specialist Emery on the sideline?

The Spanish coach has enjoyed remarkable success in Europe's second-tier competi-

tion, winning it three years running with Sevilla from 2014-16 and again with Villarreal in 2021.

Now he has led a third team with Villa' in its name to the title.

"I am always very grateful for Europe, for every competition, Conference League, Champions League, Europa League, but especially Europa League," Emery said. "We fought strongly in this competition and tried to give it our best. We played in a very serious way this year."

Two brilliant first-half strikes from Youri Tielemans and Emiliano Buendia put Villa into a 2-0 lead at the break. Morgan Rogers added a third in the second half.

German team Freiburg were outclassed in their first European final.

AGENCIES



‘THERE’S POWER IN SILENCE & COMPOSURE’

Actress Jyotika shared her experience of playing a courtroom stenographer in ‘System’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Some performances demand intensity through words, while others rely entirely on what remains unsaid. With Prime Video’s upcoming film ‘System’ building anticipation for its emotionally charged courtroom drama, one character that’s already drawing attention is Jyotika’s Sarika Rawat, a sharp, street-smart stenographer who carries an entire emotional storm beneath

‘There’s an inner depth and I consider myself very lucky that I’m attracting these kinds of roles,’ she says

her composed exterior.

Known for bringing depth and nuance to every performance, Jyotika steps into a world shaped by power, privilege and moral conflict, where some of the strongest emotions are never spoken aloud. And for the actress, that restraint became one of the most fulfilling aspects of playing Sarika.

Reflecting on portraying emotion through silence, Jyotika noted, “I think there’s a power in silence and composure. There’s an inner depth and I consider myself very lucky that I’m attracting these kinds of roles, because I feel, even as an actor, it’s a very complex emotion and at the same time, very difficult to perform. It’s always easier to perform when you have dialogues and words, but silence speaks through the eyes. I feel it’s the highest form of art for an actor to emote through silence. And I’m extremely happy because I think

it also forms the backbone of womanhood. It does translate into my character in ‘System.’”

Sharing some insights about her character, Sarika, she added, “When you see the film throughout, in the long run, I’m portraying a person whom you really cannot penetrate through the superficial level. So, I feel that in the entire three hours of watching the film, if I’m able to convince people that there’s something, some turmoil going on within me, without expressing it with words. I consider that the performance has won the hearts or has won its purpose rather.”

The movie is created and directed by Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari and produced by Pammi Baweja, Harman Baweja and Smitha Baliga under the banner of ‘Baweja Studios’. ‘System’ also stars Jyotika and Ashutosh Gowariker in pivotal roles. The ‘Original’ movie will premiere exclusively on ‘Prime Video’ on May 22.



‘IT’S NOT A PREACHY SHOW’

Raveesh Khanna talked about his new reality show ‘Tum Ho Naa’

MUMBAI: Raveesh Khanna said his new reality show, ‘Tum Ho Naa: Ghar Ki Superstar’ is an attempt to celebrate homemakers and recognise their contribution. The reality game show, hosted by Khanna, celebrates the resilience and everyday sacrifices of homemakers and women from diverse backgrounds.



The game show celebrates the resilience and everyday sacrifices of homemakers and women from diverse backgrounds

“It’s not a preachy show. We don’t preach anything. It’s just that we give them a platform, we recognise their contribution and we invite them and we call them, tell them that this is your moment. More than anything else, it’s also them feeling very special on the show because they know that they’ll be watched by millions of people,” Khanna told PTI.

At its core, he said the show isn’t about ‘standing up’ for women; it rather focuses on appreciating their contribution, which often goes unnoticed. “When I heard the concept of it and I realised women who are working in the cities have gone way ahead. But there’s still a section of our society where women, whatever they do, whatever they con-

tribute, their contribution is still not spoken about. If it’s spoken about, we still take it for granted. We don’t value and respect it. And that’s how women also deal with that. They also take it for granted that ‘This is a thankless job, we are at home. We are just doing nothing.’ Khanna called the new show his ‘thanksgiving’ to audiences, especially families and women, who have supported him over the years. PTI

‘Minotaur’ jolts Cannes Film Festival

Russian director Andrey Zvyagintsev sent shockwaves through the Cannes Film Festival with a soberly damning crime film about murder and corruption in Russia, set against the backdrop of young men into President Vladimir Putin’s war with Ukraine.

‘Minotaur’, which debuted Tuesday night at the French festival, was one of the most anticipated selections at this year’s Cannes. The film rewarded those expectations, receiving one of the festival’s most enthusiastic responses and putting the Russian filmmaker squarely in the mix for the Palme d’Or.

While ‘Minotaur’ is outwardly centred around a



married couple, its story has obvious political reverberations. Dmitry Mazurov plays the chief executive of a large shipping company who, as Russia’s military mobilises for the all-out invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, is asked to contribute a quota of 150 workers to the mounting

war effort. At the same time, Mazurov begins investigating the suspected infidelity of his wife, played by Iris Lebedeva. As ‘Minotaur’ evolves, their family drama takes on darker symbolism for the deceptions and savagery of Putin’s war. “It was important for me to make this film given the current Russian context,” Zvyagintsev told reporters on Wednesday. “It was a perfect pretext to say some important things.”

For Zvyagintsev, it was a long-awaited triumph. His previous two films, ‘Leviathan’ (2014) and ‘Loveless’ (2017), were both critically acclaimed Oscar nominees. But during the pandemic, illness forced Zvyagintsev into an induced coma for 40 days.

Recovering in a German clinic, he had to learn how to walk and hold utensils. AGENCIES

Brad Pitt returns as Cliff Booth in David Fincher’s new Netflix film

LOS ANGELES: Filmmaker David Fincher’s new feature film, which marks Hollywood star Brad Pitt’s return as stuntman Cliff Booth, will be released on ‘Netflix’ in December this year, the streamer announced.

The film, reportedly titled ‘The Adventures of Cliff Booth’, is a sequel to Quentin Tarantino’s ‘Once Upon a Time in Hollywood’ and is set in 1977 Hollywood.

The movie will open in IMAX theatres globally on November 25 for an exclusive two-week run before arriving on ‘Netflix’ on December 23, ‘Netflix’ said in a statement. Tarantino has written the screenplay, while Fincher directs. Pitt won the Academy Award for ‘Best Support-



The movie will open in IMAX theatres globally on November 25 for an exclusive two-week run

nal, will appear in the sequel.

The film’s cast also includes Elizabeth Debicki, Scott Caan, Carla Gugino, Yahya Abdul-Mateen II, Peter Weller, Matt Groove, JB Tadena, Corey Fogelmanis and Karren Karagolian.

The movie marks a reunion between Pitt and Fincher, who have previously worked together on ‘Se7en’, ‘Fight Club’ and ‘The Curious Case of Benjamin Button’. The project is produced by Pitt and Cean Chaffin. PTI

OTT HAS BEEN A BLESSING in my career: Anshuman Pushkar

ADRITA BHATTACHARYA

If you have watched ‘12th Fail’, then you must not have forgotten about Gauri Bhaiya, who opens a tea shop named ‘Restart’ and provides guidance to UPSC aspirants. Bihar-born Anshuman Pushkar didn’t require many chances to prove his mettle as an actor. From ‘Jamtara’ and ‘Graham’ to ‘Delhi Crime’ Season 3 and ‘Saali Mohabbat’, he made sure his performance always stood out in the crowd. And now, he will be seen playing the lead in ‘Satrangi: Badle Ka Khel’ on ‘Zee 5’.

In fact, he didn’t mince words when he said that the advent of OTT made actors like him noticeable.

“When I was doing theatre in Mumbai, I auditioned for roles in TV and advertisements. But OTT platforms have been a blessing in my acting career. These OTT platforms sustain art and help many actors to survive. OTT platforms have also given the option to the audience to watch a wide variety of content,” he said.

In ‘Satrangi- Badle Ka Khel’, set in a feudal landscape of the Hindi hinterland, Anshuman plays Bablu Mahto, who is forced into ‘launda naach’. The show highlights power dynamics, social hierarchies and inequalities engraved within Indian society.

The actor wants to be part of big films, but then he also said, “OTT platforms have given me a platform to showcase my art. OTT has made the lives of actors like us easier,” he said.



Bobby Deol reveals how Sandeep Reddy Vanga roped him in ‘Animal’

Though he appeared only briefly, the actor’s portrayal of Abrar Haque left a strong impact on audiences

Bobby Deol delivered one of the most talked-about performances of his career in ‘Animal’. Though he appeared only briefly, his portrayal of Abrar Haque left a strong impact on audiences.

In the episode on Shekhar Suman’s talk show, Bobby opened up about how he landed the part. He also recalled his father Dharmendra’s reaction and the anxiety he faced while waiting to begin shooting.

Bobby said he was surprised when Sandeep Reddy Vanga contacted him directly for the film. “When I got a call from Sandeep Reddy Vanga. Your expression in this photograph, I want you because I like this expression.” The actor said the director had noticed a picture of him from the Celebrity Cricket League and felt that his expression perfectly matched the character he had in mind.

Bobby previously shared more details about their first meeting in a chat with ‘Humans of Bombay’. He admitted that he was initially unsure whether the message was genuinely from the filmmaker. “I got a message from him. He introduced himself and told me he wanted to meet me for a film. I thought, ‘Is it really him?’ I called and arranged the meeting. He showed me a photo of myself from when I participated in the Celebrity Cricket League and



said, ‘I want to cast you because I love this expression of yours.’ That single photograph became the starting point for one of the most memorable roles of his career.

After the film’s release, Bobby’s father was thrilled by the response to his performance. “When ‘Animal’ came out, dad asked me, ‘Are you the villain?’ I reacted by saying ‘Yes’. I said, ‘Dad, it’s a good role’. Dad also used to say, ‘You have become Lord Bobby’.”

Bobby said he hesitated when he learned that Abrar Haque wouldn’t speak in the film. “I wanted to do something out of my comfort zone. When Sandeep told me that my character would be mute, I thought, ‘But my voice is my strength’, yet I still decided to go for it.” He later learned sign language to prepare for the part and embraced the challenge. AGENCIES

Bobby also recalled his father, Dharmendra’s reaction and the anxiety he faced while waiting to begin shooting

